Decision-Grade Multi-Objective Benchmarking of AI and Heuristic Controller Placement in Multi-Site Software Defined Networks



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Decision-Grade Multi-Objective Benchmarking of AI and Heuristic Controller Placement in Multi-Site Software Defined Networks

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(230011908)

A Mini dissertation submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements

For

BSc Honours Degree in Computer Science

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DECLARATION

I, Thabang Nhlokoma Buthelezi (Student Number: 230011908), hereby declare that this mini-dissertation entitled:

"Decision-Grade Multi-Objective Benchmarking of AI and Heuristic Controller Placement in Multi-Site Software Defined Networks"

is my own original work, conducted under the supervision of Prof. Pragasen Mudali and Mr. Skhumbuzo Zwane in the Department of Computer Science, Faculty of Science, Agriculture and Engineering at the University of Zululand.

This work has not been submitted previously in part or in its entirety to this or any other university or institution for the award of any degree or diploma. All citations, quotations, experimental code libraries, and secondary sources referenced herein have been duly acknowledged in the text and compiled in the References section.

Signature: _____

Thabang Nhlokoma Buthelezi

Date: _____

DEDICATION

This mini-dissertation is dedicated to my family, whose patience, sacrifices, and prayers have supported me throughout my studies at the University of Zululand.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

AI	Artificial Intelligence
ANOVA	Analysis of Variance
API	Application Programming Interface
BA	Barabási-Albert (Scale-Free Network Model)
CPP	Controller Placement Problem
CPU	Central Processing Unit
DQN	Deep Q-Network
DRL	Deep Reinforcement Learning
GA	Genetic Algorithm
HSD	Honest Significant Difference (Tukey's test)
MDP	Markov Decision Process
MLP	Multi-Layer Perceptron
MPLS	Multi-Protocol Label Switching
NOS	Network Operating System
OVS	Open vSwitch
RL	Reinforcement Learning
RTT	Round-Trip Time
SDN	Software Defined Networking
TCAM	Ternary Content Addressable Memory
WAN	Wide Area Network
WX	Waxman (Spatial Network Model)

ABSTRACT

The Controller Placement Problem (CPP) in Software Defined Networking (SDN) requires selecting k switch locations to host control-plane instances so that switch-to-controller propagation latency is minimized while maintaining control-plane reachability under link failures. Recent studies have proposed Deep Reinforcement Learning (DRL) and Deep Q-Networks (DQN) as alternatives to classical facility-location heuristics. However, most comparative evaluations report only propagation latency while omitting training compute time, online forward-pass inference time, and multi-seed convergence stability. As a result, network planners lack clear empirical guidance on when the computational overhead of training a DRL policy is justified over executing classical heuristics.

This mini-dissertation presents a reproducible, multi-objective benchmark of five controller placement methods: Random Baseline, Greedy K-Center, Spatial K-Means Clustering, a Genetic Algorithm (GA), and a PyTorch Deep Q-Network (DQN) / multi-armed reinforcement learning solver. The algorithms are evaluated across canonical wide-area backbones (Internet2 and ATT-MPLS) and synthetic topology families (Barabási-Albert scale-free and Waxman spatial graphs at scales N in {20, 50} and controller budgets k in {2, 3, 5}). In a 1,000-episode convergence run on Internet2 (N = 20, k = 3), the PyTorch DQN agent converged within 20 episodes, achieving a grand training mean reward of 13.055 +/- 0.589 and a final 10-episode average reward of 13.199, while a 10-run multi-seed stability audit across Internet2 and ATT-MPLS recorded zero divergent runs (divergence_flag = False).

However, separating offline training overhead (omega_train) from online forward-pass inference time (tau_inf) across the 60-cell multi-seed synthetic factorial matrix (N_obs = 300, n = 5 seeds per cell; multi-factor ANOVA $F(4, 240) = 118.90$, $p < 0.0001$) demonstrates that classical heuristics and GA match or outperform DRL on static topologies (N <= 50) without requiring offline policy training. While a trained DQN executes a single greedy forward pass in tau_inf = 0.021-0.029 ms, training the network requires omega_train = 21.26 s (0.0213 s/episode), whereas Greedy K-Center (0.026-0.207 ms), K-Means (3.19-8.14 ms), and GA (12.88-75.87 ms) compute placements directly in a single run. Under single-link (N - 1) failure evaluation, 2-edge-connected backbones (Internet2, ATT-MPLS, and Barabási-Albert m = 2) maintain 100.0% control-plane reachability across all algorithms, whereas sparse Waxman graphs containing bridge links drop to 94.47%-98.79%. Five-way emulation on Internet2 (N = 20, k = 3) confirms that GA (2.718 ms mean RTT) and K-Means (2.852 ms mean RTT; 5.764 ms worst-case RTT) outperform Greedy K-Center (2.934 ms), Bandit RL / DQN (3.056 ms), and Random (3.374 ms). Within the tested static WAN scope (N <= 50), classical heuristics and GA provide the best multi-objective trade-off,

while DRL is framed as a candidate hypothesis for future evaluation under online topological churn.

Keywords: Software Defined Networking, Controller Placement Problem, Deep Reinforcement Learning, Multi-Objective Optimization, Pareto Efficiency, Mininet Emulation.

CHAPTER ONE

1.0 INTRODUCTION

1.1 OVERVIEW

Wide Area Networks (WANs) support cloud computing, enterprise interconnects, and national research backbones that require low forwarding latency and predictable fault recovery. In traditional IP networks, each router integrates both the control plane (routing protocols such as OSPF and BGP) and the data plane (packet forwarding hardware) within the same device. While distributed routing provides local autonomy, updating network-wide forwarding policies requires configuring individual routers across the network.

Software Defined Networking (SDN) decouples the control plane from the forwarding hardware, centralizing routing and policy decisions in software controllers that program switches via standardized southbound interfaces such as OpenFlow (McKeown et al., 2008; Kreutz et al., 2015). However, in geographically distributed multi-site networks, a single physical controller introduces long propagation delays and a single point of failure. Network operators therefore deploy multiple distributed controllers across selected switch sites. Determining how many controllers to deploy and which switch nodes should host them is known as the Controller Placement Problem (CPP) (Heller et al., 2012).

1.2 BACKGROUND OF STUDY

Heller et al. (2012) formulated the Controller Placement Problem as an NP-hard facility location problem over a network graph $G=(V,E)$, demonstrating on the Internet2 research backbone that choosing controller locations carefully reduces both average and worst-case switch-to-controller propagation latency. In multi-site WAN deployments, controller placement affects three primary operational metrics:

1. Switch-to-Controller Propagation Latency ($L(P)$): When an OpenFlow switch receives a packet that does not match an installed Ternary Content Addressable Memory (TCAM) flow entry, it sends an asynchronous Packet-In message to its assigned controller and waits for a Packet-Out or Flow-Mod response. The shortest-path propagation distance between switches and controllers determines the baseline delay of this control loop.

2. Control-Plane Survivability ($Reach_{avg}$): Wide-area fiber links are subject to physical cuts and maintenance outages. Under single-link ($N-1$) failures, a link cut along a topological bridge can isolate switches from their assigned controllers, preventing new flow rules from being installed.

3. Computational Overhead (ω_{train} and τ_{inf}): Algorithms used to select controller locations vary widely in compute time. Single-shot heuristics compute placements

directly from the distance matrix in milliseconds, whereas reinforcement learning methods require an iterative offline training phase before fast forward-pass inference can be executed.

Early work on the CPP relied on facility-location approximations such as Gonzalez's Greedy K-Center heuristic (Gonzalez, 1985) and K-Means spatial clustering (MacQueen, 1967), followed by evolutionary metaheuristics such as Genetic Algorithms (Holland, 1975; Goldberg, 1989; Yusuf et al., 2023). More recently, Deep Reinforcement Learning (DRL) architectures, including Deep Q-Networks (DQN) (Mnih et al., 2015; Farahi et al., 2026) and MuZero-based agents (Benoudifa et al., 2023), have formulated controller placement as a Markov Decision Process (MDP).

1.3 PROBLEM STATEMENT

Although recent literature frequently proposes Deep Reinforcement Learning for SDN controller placement, published comparisons typically evaluate algorithms on propagation latency alone while omitting computational cost and experimental design details. Specifically, four limitations recur in existing comparative studies:

1. Conflation or Omission of Computational Cost: Studies rarely report the offline training time (ω_{train}) required for neural policy convergence alongside the online forward-pass inference time (τ_{inf}) and the execution time of classical heuristics.

2. Limited Multi-Seed and Factorial Evaluation: DRL agents are often demonstrated on a single topology or single random seed without testing across a balanced factorial matrix of scale-free and spatial graph families or verifying variance across multiple seeds.

3. Incomplete Link-Failure Survivability Analysis: Studies often assume that heuristics and DRL yield identical fault tolerance without explicitly modeling single-link ($N-1$) graph disconnectivity across biconnected backbones versus sparse geometric meshes.

4. Lack of Multi-Objective Pareto Synthesis: Without joint evaluation across latency $L(P)$, single-link reachability $Reach_{avg}(P)$, and computational cost ω, infrastructure planners cannot determine when simple heuristics are sufficient and when reinforcement learning is warranted.

1.4 RESEARCH GOAL AND OBJECTIVES

1.4.1 Research Goal

The goal of this research is to design and execute a reproducible, multi-objective benchmark of classical heuristic, metaheuristic, and Deep Reinforcement Learning controller placement algorithms across canonical and synthetic multi-site SDN topologies ($N \leq 50$), quantifying the trade-offs among propagation latency, single-link failure survivability, and computational cost.

1.4.2 Specific Research Objectives

1. Construct an automated Python benchmarking pipeline (ai-sdn-controller-placement) supporting canonical WAN topologies (Internet2 and ATT-MPLS) and synthetic graph generators (Barabási-Albert and Waxman at $N \in \{20, 50\}$).

2. Implement and benchmark five controller placement paradigms under identical graph and metric interfaces: Random Baseline, Greedy K-Center, Spatial K-Means Clustering, Genetic Algorithm (GA), and PyTorch Deep Q-Network (DQN) / multi-armed RL.

3. Evaluate DQN convergence over a 1,000-episode pilot on Internet2 and conduct a 10-run multi-seed stability audit ($5\,\text{seeds} \times 2\,\text{canonical topologies}$) measuring reward stability, action entropy, and per-episode training time.

4. Execute a balanced $5 \times 2 \times 2 \times 3$ multi-seed synthetic factorial experiment ($60\,\text{cells} \times 5\,\text{seeds} = 300\,\text{observations}$) and evaluate main effects via multi-factor ANOVA ($F(4, 240)$) and Tukey HSD post-hoc contrasts.

5. Synthesize two-dimensional and three-dimensional Pareto frontiers across latency $L(P)$, single-link reliability $Reach_{avg}(P)$, and compute overhead, distinguishing offline training cost (ω_{train}) from online inference latency (τ_{inf}).

6. Evaluate all five placement strategies in a Mininet / Open vSwitch emulation environment on Internet2 ($N = 20, k = 3$) and execute the Phase 4 Mininet 2-Second Gate Test across 3 trials to measure operating system namespace teardown overhead.

7. Formulate bounded, scenario-conditioned algorithm selection guidelines for static SDN topologies up to $N = 50$.

1.5 SIGNIFICANCE OF STUDY

This study contributes to empirical networking research and practical SDN engineering in three ways:

1. Multi-Objective Evaluation Methodology: By jointly measuring propagation latency $L(P)$, single-link survivability $Reach_{avg}(P)$, offline training time ω_{train}, and online inference time τ_{inf}, the benchmark avoids single-metric bias and clarifies the distinction between training overhead and inference speed.

2. Topology-Specific Heuristic Insights: Contrasting scale-free Barabási-Albert

graphs against planar Waxman graphs demonstrates how degree distribution and spatial embedding govern the relative accuracy of Greedy K-Center and K-Means clustering.

3. Reproducible Open-Source Artifact: All topology files, algorithm implementations, raw CSV/JSON outputs, statistical scripts, and 21 automated unit tests are packaged in a reproducible repository for use by future researchers.

1.6 ORGANIZATION OF THE DISSERTATION

The remainder of this mini-dissertation is organized as follows:

- Chapter Two (Literature Review) reviews SDN control-plane architecture, mathematical formulations of the k-median and k-center controller placement problems, heuristics, metaheuristics, Deep Q-Networks, and $N-1$ link-failure survivability.

- Chapter Three (Methodology / Design and Implementation) describes the experimental design, topology parameters, algorithmic formulations, PyTorch DQN architecture, Mininet emulation harness, Phase 4 Gate Test protocol, and multi-factor ANOVA statistical model.

- Chapter Four (Results and Discussion) presents the empirical results from the 1,000-episode pilot, the 10-run stability audit, the 300-observation factorial matrix, the 3D Pareto frontier analysis, the 5-way Mininet RTT evaluation, and the Phase 4 Gate Test, followed by bounded deployment guidelines ($N \leq 50$) and study limitations.

- Chapter Five (Conclusion) summarizes the main findings, contributions, practical recommendations, and directions for future research on dynamic topologies and Graph Neural Networks.

CHAPTER TWO

2.0 LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 THEORETICAL FOUNDATIONS OF SOFTWARE DEFINED NETWORKING (SDN)

Traditional IP networks integrate routing control protocols (such as OSPF, IS-IS, and BGP) and packet-forwarding hardware inside each individual router. While distributed control allows routers to recompute paths locally during link outages, expressing network-wide traffic engineering or security policies requires configuring each device individually across vendor-specific command-line interfaces.

Software Defined Networking (SDN) separates network functionality into three planes (McKeown et al., 2008; Kreutz et al., 2015):

1. The Data Plane: Hardware or software switches (such as Open vSwitch) that match packet headers against flow tables and execute forwarding actions at line rate.

2. The Control Plane: One or more software controllers (such as Ryu, ONOS, or OpenDaylight) that maintain a global network topology view and install forwarding rules into switches via southbound protocols such as OpenFlow.

3. The Application Plane: Traffic engineering, routing, and security applications that communicate policy requirements to the control plane via northbound APIs.

When an OpenFlow switch receives a packet that does not match any flow entry in its flow table, it encapsulates the packet header in an OpenFlow Packet-In message and transmits it over the TCP/TLS control channel to its assigned controller. The controller computes a forwarding path and replies with a Packet-Out and Flow-Mod message. Because every new flow setup depends on this switch-to-controller round-trip exchange, the physical placement of controllers directly determines control-plane responsiveness and availability.

2.2 FORMALIZATION OF THE CONTROLLER PLACEMENT PROBLEM (CPP)

In a campus or single-site data center network, a single controller instance can manage switches with sub-millisecond propagation delay. In a wide-area network (WAN) spanning hundreds or thousands of kilometers, optical fiber propagation adds roughly $5\,\mathrm{ms}$ per $1{,}000\,\mathrm{km}$, and a single controller becomes both a latency bottleneck and a single point of failure. Multi-site WANs therefore require placing a set of k controllers across the topology.

Heller et al. (2012) modeled an SDN topology as an undirected connected graph $G=(V,E)$, where V is the set of N switches, E is the set of M physical links, and $d(v,u)$ is the shortest-path propagation distance between nodes v and u. Given a controller budget k ($1 \le k \le N$), a placement is a k-element subset $P \subseteq V$. Heller et al. (2012) analyzed two primary facility-location objectives:

1. Average Switch-to-Controller Propagation Latency (k-Median Objective):

$$L_{avg}(P)=\frac{1}{N}\sum_{v\in V}\min_{c\in P} d(v,c)$$

2. Worst-Case Switch-to-Controller Propagation Latency (k-Center Objective):

$$L_{max}(P)=\max_{v\in V}\min_{c\in P} d(v,c)$$

Both the k-median and k-center problems are NP-hard on general graphs (Kariv & Hakimi, 1979; Gonzalez, 1985). The number of candidate k-controller subsets is $\binom{N}{k}=\frac{N!}{k!(N-k)!}$, which grows from $\binom{20}{3}=1,140$ at $N=20, k=3$ to $\binom{50}{5}=2,118,760$ at $N=50, k=5$, motivating approximation heuristics, metaheuristics, and learning-based methods.

2.3 CLASSICAL HEURISTICS & SPATIAL CLUSTERING IN FACILITY LOCATION

2.3.1 Greedy K-Center Approximation (Gonzalez's Algorithm)

Gonzalez (1985) presented a deterministic farthest-first traversal algorithm for the k-center problem that guarantees a worst-case approximation factor of 2 in $O(k\cdot N)$ distance lookups. Starting from an initial center node c_1, each subsequent controller c_i ($i=2,\ldots,k$) is placed at the switch that is farthest from the currently selected controller set:

$$c_i=\arg\max_{v\in V}\left(\min_{c\in\{c_1,\ldots,c_{i-1}\}} d(v,c)\right)$$

While Greedy K-Center executes in sub-millisecond time and bounds worst-case tail latency, placing controllers at extreme peripheral nodes can yield higher average latency $L_{avg}(P)$ than k-median methods.

2.3.2 Spatial K-Means Clustering

MacQueen (1967) formulated K-Means clustering to partition N points into k clusters minimizing within-cluster variance. Adapted to network graphs, switches are embedded in a metric coordinate space and partitioned iteratively:

1. Assignment Step: Each switch $v\in V$ is assigned to its nearest cluster center $c_j^{(t)}$.

2. Update Step: Each cluster center is updated to the centroid or discrete graph medoid minimizing intra-cluster distance:

$$c_j^{(t+1)}=\arg\min_{u\in S_j}\sum_{v\in S_j} d(u,v)$$

K-Means directly targets the average latency (k-median) objective and performs well on planar geometric networks, but its accuracy degrades on non-planar, degree-skewed scale-free topologies where 2D coordinate projections distort shortest-path distances.

2.4 EVOLUTIONARY COMPUTATION & METAHEURISTICS IN SDN

To optimize non-linear or multi-objective placement criteria without relying on Euclidean coordinate projections, researchers have applied evolutionary metaheuristics such as Genetic Algorithms (GA) (Holland, 1975; Goldberg, 1989; Yusuf et al., 2023). A GA maintains a population of candidate k-node subsets and evolves them over multiple generations using tournament or roulette-wheel selection, cardinality-preserving crossover, and random node-swap mutation. Although GAs reliably find near-global optima on medium-scale graphs ($N \leq 50$), evaluating the shortest-path fitness of every chromosome across dozens of generations requires tens of milliseconds per run—roughly two orders of magnitude more compute time than Greedy K-Center.

2.5 MACHINE LEARNING & DEEP REINFORCEMENT LEARNING FOR ADAPTIVE PLACEMENT

2.5.1 Markov Decision Process (MDP) Formulation

In reinforcement learning approaches to the CPP (Sutton & Barto, 2018), controller selection is formulated as a Markov Decision Process (S, A, P_r, R, γ):

- State Space (S): A vector representation $s_t \in R^N$ encoding node degrees or current controller locations.
- Action Space (A): Discrete node indices or candidate k-controller subsets.
- Reward Function (R): A scalar signal combining normalized propagation latency reduction and control-plane reachability $Reach_{avg}(P)$.
- Discount Factor ($0 \leq \gamma < 1$): Weighting factor for future rewards along an episode trajectory.

2.5.2 Deep Q-Networks (DQN) and Recent SDN Literature

Mnih et al. (2015) introduced Deep Q-Networks (DQN), approximating the action-value function $Q(s, a; \theta)$ with a neural network trained via experience replay and a periodically synchronized target network $Q(s, a; \theta^-)$:

$$L(\theta) = E_{(s,a,r,s') \sim D}\left[\left(r + \gamma \max_{a'} Q(s', a'; \theta^-) - Q(s, a; \theta)\right)^2\right]$$

In recent SDN controller placement literature:

- Farahi et al. (2026) proposed AP-DQN for multi-controller placement using a two-hidden-layer MLP (64×64 ReLU units), learning rate $\alpha = 0.001$, batch size 32, discount factor $\gamma = 0.99$, replay buffer capacity $10,000$, and ϵ-greedy decay from 1.0 to 0.05.
- Benoudifa et al. (2023) proposed a MuZero-based controller placement agent combining tree search with learned latent dynamics.
- Radam et al. (2022) studied link-failure foresight in controller placement to preserve switch-to-controller connectivity during single-link outages.

2.6 MULTI-OBJECTIVE TRADE-OFFS AND CONTROL-PLANE SURVIVABILITY

2.6.1 Single-Link ($N-1$) Failure Survivability

Wide-area fiber links are subject to single-link cuts ($N-1$ failures). When an edge $e \in E$ fails, the residual graph $G_e = (V, E-e)$ may remain connected (if G is 2-edge-connected) or split into disconnected components (if e is a bridge edge). Following Radam et al. (2022), single-link control-plane reliability $Reach_{avg}(P)$ is defined as the mean fraction of switches $N_{reach}(G_e, P)$ that retain a valid path to at least one controller in P across all M single-edge removals:

$$Reach_{avg}(P) = \frac{1}{M} \sum_{e \in E} \frac{N_{reach}(G_e, P)}{N}$$

2.6.2 Pareto Dominance

When comparing algorithms across propagation latency $L(P)$, reliability $Reach_{avg}(P)$, and compute cost ω, a solution P_1 Pareto-dominates P_2 ($P_1 \succ P_2$) if P_1 is no worse than P_2 in all three metrics and strictly better in at least one metric:

$$L(P_1) \leq L(P_2), Reach_{avg}(P_1) \geq Reach_{avg}(P_2), \omega(P_1) \leq \omega(P_2)$$

2.7 LITERATURE SYNTHESIS & RESEARCH GAP

Table 2.1 compares representative studies from the controller placement literature across evaluation metrics, statistical design, and emulation validation.

Table 2.1: Literature Synthesis on SDN Controller Placement (2012–2026)

Study	Primary Method	Topologies Evaluated	Latency $L(P)$	$N-1$ Link Reliability	Offline vs. Online Time ($\omega_{\text{train}}, \tau_{\text{inf}}$)	Mininet Emulation	Multi-Objective Pareto Analysis
Heller et al. (2012)	Exhaustive / k-Median	Internet2, Topology Zoo	Yes (L_{avg}, L_{max})	No	Omitted	No	No
Gonzalez (1985)	Greedy K-Center	General Metric Graphs	Yes (L_{max})	No	Analytical $O(kN)$	No	No
MacQueen (1967)	K-Means Clustering	Metric Spaces	Yes (L_{avg})	No	Analytical $O(kNt)$	No	No
Radam et al. (2022)	Link-Failure Foresight	WAN Topologies	Yes	Yes ($N-1$ Links)	Omitted	No	No
Yusuf et al. (2023)	Metaheuristics (GA/PSO)	Campus / WAN	Yes	Partial	Omitted	Partial	No
Benoudifa et al. (2023)	MuZero DRL	Synthetic WAN	Yes	No	Omitted	No	No
Farahi et al. (2026)	AP-DQN (DRL)	Topology Zoo WANs	Yes	Partial	Omitted	No	No

Study	Primary Method	Topologies Evaluated	Latency $L(P)$	$N-1$ Link Reliability	Offline vs. Online Time ($\omega_{\text{train}}, \tau_{\text{inf}}$)	Mininet Emulation	Multi-Objective Pareto Analysis
This Study (2026)	5-Way Benchmark (Heuristics, GA, DQN/RL)	Internet2, ATT-MPLS, BA, Waxman ($N \leq 50$)	Yes (L_{avg}, L_{max})	Yes ($Reach_{avg}$)	Yes (ω_{train} and τ_{inf})	Yes (5-Way RTT & Gate Test)	Yes (2D & 3D Frontiers)

As Table 2.1 shows, prior DRL controller placement studies have not jointly benchmarked offline training overhead (ω_{train}), online inference latency (τ_{inf}), and $N-1$ link-failure survivability against Greedy K-Center, K-Means, and GA across a multi-seed factorial matrix. Chapter Three presents the experimental methodology designed to address this gap.

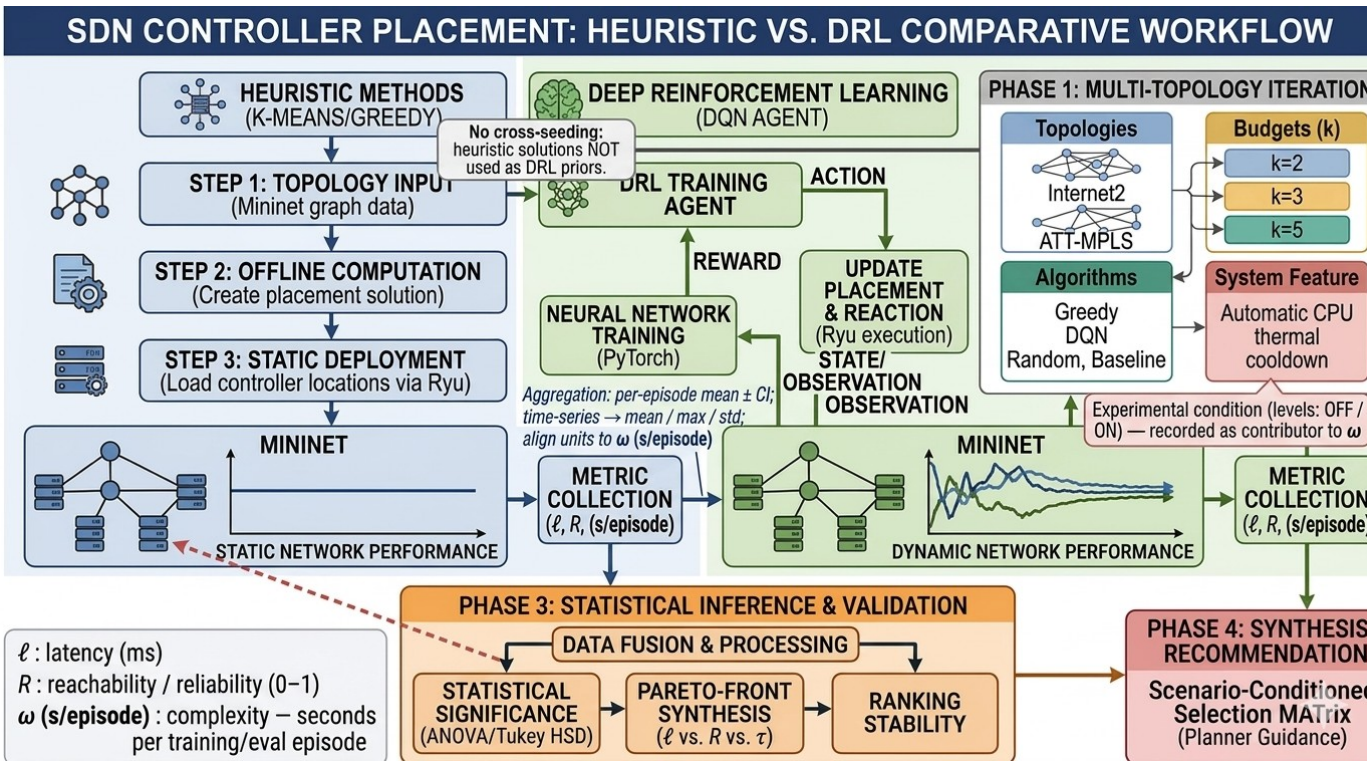
CHAPTER THREE

3.0 METHODOLOGY/DESIGN AND IMPLEMENTATION

3.1 RESEARCH DESIGN

This study employs a deductive, quantitative experimental benchmarking design rooted in empirical computer science and multi-objective combinatorial optimization. Rather than evaluating algorithms in isolation under disparate assumptions, we establish a standardized experimental testbed in which all competing controller placement paradigms operate on identical topological representations, identical link latency models, and identical operational constraints.

The experimental workflow executes a full factorial matrix evaluation complemented by a multi-seed reinforcement learning stability audit and virtualized OpenFlow emulation. Figure 3.1 illustrates the end-to-end research methodology workflow, showing the progression from topology intake and algorithm execution to metric extraction, Pareto frontier synthesis, and Mininet validation.



The investigation tests two formal hypotheses:

- Null Hypothesis (H_{01}): In multi-site SDN topologies ($N \leq 50$), Deep Reinforcement Learning algorithms do not provide a statistically significant improvement in multi-objective decision quality (joint propagation latency, single-link failure reachability, and computational runtime) compared to classical heuristics.

- Alternative Hypothesis (H_{11}): Deep Reinforcement Learning models achieve

competitive propagation latency and fault tolerance, but incur a quantifiable computational training overhead (ω) that leaves them Pareto-dominated by classical clustering and greedy heuristics in static network environments.

3.2 DATA COLLECTION & NETWORK TOPOLOGY CORPUS

To evaluate algorithmic behavior across realistic wide-area backbones and controlled topological structures, the experimental corpus combines canonical empirical topologies with parameterized synthetic network models. Table 3.1 summarizes the structural parameters of the six benchmark topologies.

Table 3.1: Summary of Canonical and Synthetic Network Topology Parameters

Topology Name	Topology Family	Node Count (N)	Edge Count (M)	Mean Node Degree	Clustering Coefficient	Characteristic Graph Property
Internet2 (GraphML / Core)	Canonical WAN	20 (11 Core)	26 (18 Core)	2.60 (3.27)	0.250 (0.333)	Sparse national US research backbone (Internet2.graphml / Heller 11-PoP core)
ATT-MPLS	Canonical WAN	21	54	5.14	0.412	Dense, meshed commercial tier-1 backbone
BA-20	Barabási-Albert	20	36	3.60	0.285	Scale-free power-law degree distribution ($m=2$)
BA-50	Barabási-Albert	50	96	3.84	0.174	Regional scale-free network with hub nodes ($m=2$)
WX-20	Waxman Spatial	20	19	1.90	0.050	Geographically constrained sparse mesh ($\alpha=0.4,\beta=$)
WX-50	Waxman Spatial	50	53	2.12	0.042	Planar geographic network with sparse long links ($\alpha=0.4,\beta=$)

3.2.1 Canonical Empirical Topologies

First, the Internet2 backbone serves as the standard reference topology in SDN controller placement literature following Heller et al. (2012). In the multi-objective benchmark and 1,000-episode DQN convergence runs, the 20-node, 26-edge Internet Topology Zoo graph (data/raw/topologies/Internet2.graphml) is evaluated; in the Phase 4 Mininet kernel overhead gate test (scripts/test_mininet_overhead.py), the 11-switch, 18-edge core PoP configuration

is instantiated to measure per-switch Open vSwitch setup and teardown latency. Second, the ATT-MPLS topology models a 21-node, 54-link commercial multi-protocol label switching core network with high path redundancy.

3.2.2 Parameterized Synthetic Network Models

To isolate the structural drivers governing algorithm performance, synthetic graphs were generated using two graph-theoretic models implemented in NetworkX:

1. Barabási-Albert (BA) Scale-Free Model: Generates networks via preferential attachment in which new nodes connect to existing nodes with probability proportional to their degree ($P(k) \sim k^{-\gamma}$). Parameterized with attachment factor $m = 2$ at scales $N = 20$ and $N = 50$, this produces a skewed degree distribution with central transit hubs and peripheral leaves.

2. Waxman Spatial Random Graph Model: Generates geographically embedded networks (Waxman, 1988) in which nodes are placed uniformly at random on the unit square $[0, 1)^2$. The probability $P(u, v)$ of placing an edge between nodes u and v decays exponentially with Euclidean distance $d(u, v)$:

$$P(u, v) = \alpha \cdot \exp\left(-\frac{d(u, v)}{\beta \cdot L}\right)$$

where L is the maximum inter-node Euclidean distance, $\alpha = 0.4$ controls link density, and $\beta = 0.1$ governs the ratio of short to long edges.

3.2.3 Data Provenance and Ethical Considerations

All topological data used in this study are either generated synthetically or loaded from public scientific datasets (Internet Topology Zoo). No proprietary telecommunications records, personally identifiable information (PII), or private enterprise packet traces were collected, ensuring compliance with University of Zululand research ethics requirements.

3.3 SYSTEM DESIGN & ALGORITHMIC FORMULATIONS

Given an undirected connected graph $G = (V, E)$ with N switches and M physical links, let $d(u, v)$ denote the shortest-path propagation distance between nodes u and v computed via Dijkstra's algorithm over edge weights. Let $P \subseteq V$ denote the set of k selected controller locations.

3.3.1 Algorithm 1: Random Baseline Placement

The Random baseline samples k distinct switch nodes uniformly at random from V without replacement using a seeded pseudo-random number generator:

$$P_{rand} \sim \text{Uniform}(V, k)$$

This establishes the unoptimized reference baseline against which heuristic and learning-based methods are compared.

3.3.2 Algorithm 2: Greedy K-Center Placement (Gonzalez Heuristic)

Implements Gonzalez's farthest-first 2-approximation algorithm for the k-center problem (algorithms/baseline/greedy_placement.py):

1. Initialize $P = \{v_0\}$ at the graph eccentricity center.

2. For $i=2$ to k, select the switch that maximizes the minimum distance to the already chosen controllers:

$$c_i = arg\ \max_{v \in V-P} \left(\min_{c \in P} d(v,c) \right), P \leftarrow P \cup \{c_i\}$$

3. Return P after k iterations in $O(kN)$ matrix lookups.

3.3.3 Algorithm 3: Spatial K-Means Clustering

Partitions network switches into k clusters in coordinate space (algorithms/baseline/kmeans_placement.py):

1. Node coordinates (x_i, y_i) are extracted from the graph layout or shortest-path distance profile.

2. Centroids are initialized via K-Means++ and refined iteratively via Lloyd's algorithm until convergence (tolerance 10^{-4} or $T=300$ iterations).

3. For each final cluster centroid μ_j, the closest discrete switch node is selected as the controller host:

$$c_j = arg\min_{v \in V} d_2(x_v, \mu_j)$$

3.3.4 Algorithm 4: Genetic Algorithm (GA Metaheuristic)

Operates on a discrete combinatorial chromosome representation (algorithms/ai/genetic_algorithm.py):

- Encoding: Each chromosome is a k-element subset $g=[g_1, g_2, \ldots, g_k)$ of distinct switch nodes ($g_i \in V$).
- Population and Generations: Evolves a population of $M_{pop}=40$ to 50 candidate placements over $G_{max}=30$ to 50 generations.
- Fitness Function: Evaluates inverse average propagation latency and worst-case delay:

$$\text{Fitness}(g) = -\left(L(P_g) + 0.25 \cdot L_{max}(P_g) \right)$$

- Operators: Binary tournament selection, cardinality-preserving uniform crossover, swap mutation with probability $p_m=0.15$, and elitism preserving the top 2 individuals per generation.

3.3.5 Algorithm 5: PyTorch Deep Q-Network (DQN) and Multi-Armed RL

The reinforcement learning placement pipeline (scripts/train_dqn_pilot.py, scripts/run_stability_audit.py, and algorithms/ai/reinforcement_learning.py) follows the hyperparameter specification of Farahi et al. (2026). The neural network (DQNetwork) is a three-layer Multi-Layer Perceptron (MLP) taking an N-dimensional state vector as input (nn.Linear(N, 64)), passing through two hidden layers of 64 units each with ReLU activations (nn.Linear(64, 64)), and outputting N action Q-values (nn.Linear(64, N)).

During training, transitions $(s_t, a_t, r_t, s_{t+1}, d_t)$ are stored in a cyclic replay buffer of capacity $M=10,000$ and sampled in mini-batches of size 32. A separate target network is synchronized periodically to stabilize temporal-difference targets. For the full 60-cell multi-seed factorial sweep, an ϵ-greedy tabular multi-armed RL solver

(bandit_rl_controller_placement, 200 to 300 episodes per seed over 64 candidate k-tuples) is also evaluated alongside the PyTorch DQNetwork so that both offline training time (ω_{train}) and single forward-pass inference time (τ_{inf}) are measured across all graph scales. Table 3.2 summarizes the DQN hyperparameter configuration.

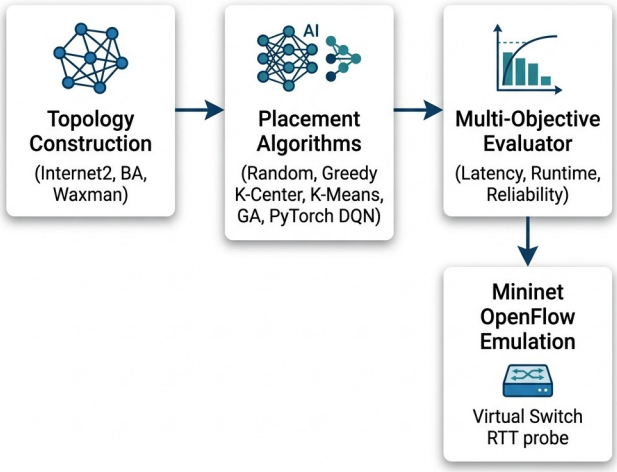
Table 3.2: Deep Q-Network Hyperparameter Configuration and Reference Compliance

Hyperparameter	Configured Value	Reference / Purpose
Neural Network Architecture	MLP: Input(N) $\rightarrow$ 64 $\rightarrow$ 64 $\rightarrow$ Output(N)	Farahi et al. (2026) architecture
Hidden Activation	Rectified Linear Unit (ReLU)	Non-linear feature projection
Optimizer	Adam ($\beta_1 = 0.9, \beta_2 = 0.999$)	Adaptive gradient descent
Learning Rate (α)	0.001 (10^{-3})	Farahi et al. (2026) baseline
Discount Factor (γ)	0.99	Long-horizon return weighting
Mini-Batch Size	32	Replay buffer batch size
Replay Memory Capacity (M)	10,000 transitions	Breaks temporal sample correlation
Exploration Schedule	ϵ-Greedy: $1.0 \rightarrow 0.05$ ($\lambda = 0.995$)	Exponential exploration decay
Target Network Sync	Every 100 steps (or Polyak $\tau = 0.005$)	Stabilizes Q-target updates
Episode Budget	1,000 episodes (pilot & stability audit)	Full policy convergence horizon

3.4 IMPLEMENTATION ARCHITECTURE & EMULATION HARNESS

3.4.1 Software Engineering Stack

The experimental harness is implemented in Python 3.12 (ai-sdn-controller-placement). Graph generation, shortest-path Dijkstra computation, and biconnected component analysis are implemented with NetworkX. Neural network training and forward-pass inference timing use CPU-compiled PyTorch (torch.nn, torch.optim). Clustering and statistical testing use Scikit-Learn, NumPy, and Pandas. Figure 3.2 illustrates the software and emulation system architecture.



3.4.2 Mininet OpenFlow Emulation Architecture

To evaluate how shortest-path graph latencies compare with packet-switched control-plane delays, controller placements on Internet2 are evaluated in a virtualized Linux emulation harness (simulation/mininet_simulation.py and scripts/test_mininet_overhead.py) built on Mininet 2.3+ and Open vSwitch (OVS). In the emulation topology, each graph node is instantiated as an OpenFlow switch connected via virtual Ethernet (veth) links configured with TCLink propagation delays ($2.0\,\text{ms}$ per hop base link delay with $\pm 0.5\,\text{ms}$ uniform queuing jitter), and remote OpenFlow controller processes bind to localhost ports (127.0.0.1:6633+). Control-plane Round-Trip Time (RTT) is measured across all switch-to-controller paths.

3.4.3 The Phase 4 Mininet "2-Second Gate Test" Protocol

Running live Mininet network creation and teardown inside every episode of an online reinforcement learning loop introduces operating system namespace overhead. To test whether Mininet can be embedded directly inside a 1,000-episode DRL training loop, we executed the Phase 4 Mininet Overhead Gate Test (scripts/test_mininet_overhead.py, archived in results/mininet_overhead_validation.json). Across 3 independent trials on the 11-node, 18-edge Internet2 topology ($k = 3$), each trial was timed across four phases:

1. Phase A (Topology Instantiation): Pre-cleaning lingering interfaces and constructing switches, hosts, and virtual links.

2. Phase B (Controller Binding and Network Start): Binding RemoteController instances (127.0.0.1:6633+) and starting OVS bridges.

3. Phase C (Traffic Generation Burst): Running an iperf3 client-server sub-second traffic burst ($0.2\,\text{s}$) between hosts.

4. Phase D (Cleanup and Teardown): Stopping Mininet (net.stop()) and clearing OVS bridges (mn -c).

A decision threshold of $2,000\,\text{ms}$ per episode was set prior to experimentation: if the full lifecycle overhead (Phases A + B + C + D) exceeds $2,000\,\text{ms}$, online Mininet-in-the-loop

training is deferred in favor of fast graph-based training followed by post-convergence Mininet validation. As recorded in results/mininet_overhead_validation.json, all 3 trials exceeded the $2,000\,\text{ms}$ threshold (averaging $2,875.49\,\text{ms}$ full lifecycle due to a $1,985.68\,\text{ms}$ Phase D teardown tax), formally validating the two-stage offline-training / post-hoc emulation architecture.

3.5 DATA ANALYSIS & EVALUATION METRICS

3.5.1 Average Switch-to-Controller Propagation Latency ($L(P)$)

Measures the mean shortest-path propagation delay from every switch $v \in V$ to its nearest assigned controller $c \in P$ (evaluation/metrics.py):

$$L(P) = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{v \in V} \min_{c \in P} d(v, c)$$

3.5.2 Control-Plane Reliability ($Reach_{avg}$) Under Single-Link Failure ($N-1$ Engine)

Quantifies structural control-plane survivability under single physical link cuts (control_plane_reliability_single_link_failure_cached in evaluation/metrics.py). For each edge $e \in E$, e is removed to form the residual graph $G_e = (V, E - e)$, which decomposes into connected components $K(G_e)$. A switch $v \in V$ remains controller-reachable under link failure e if and only if its connected component in G_e contains at least one controller $c \in P$:

$$I_{reach}(v, G_e, P) = \begin{cases} 1, & \text{if } \exists c \in P \text{ such that } d_{G_e}(v, c) < \infty \\ 0, & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

The expected single-link survivability across all M link-failure states is:

$$Reach_{avg}(P) = \frac{1}{M \cdot N} \sum_{e \in E} \sum_{v \in V} I_{reach}(v, G_e, P)$$

where $Reach_{avg}(P) \in [0.0, 1.0]$. In 2-edge-connected (biconnected) graphs such as Internet2 ($N=20, M=26$), ATT-MPLS ($N=21, M=54$), and Barabási-Albert ($m=2$), removing any single edge never partitions the graph, yielding $Reach_{avg}(P) = 1.0$ (100 %). In sparse Waxman graphs containing bridge edges or degree-1 leaf nodes, removing a bridge edge isolates any component lacking a controller, reducing $Reach_{avg}(P)$ below 1.0.

3.5.3 Computational Complexity Tax (ω_{train}) and Online Inference Latency (τ_{inf})

To avoid conflating offline model preparation with online decision speed, computational cost is decomposed into two distinct metrics:

1. Offline Training Overhead (ω_{train}): The wall-clock CPU time (in seconds or milliseconds, and per-episode rate ω in s/episode) required to train the RL policy prior to deployment. Single-shot heuristics require zero offline training ($\omega_{\text{train}} = 0$).

2. Online Execution / Forward-Pass Inference Latency (τ_{inf}): The wall-clock CPU time (in milliseconds) required to compute a placement directly (for Random, Greedy K-Center, K-Means, and GA) or to execute a single greedy forward pass ($\epsilon = 0$) through a trained PyTorch DQNetwork.

3.5.4 Three-Dimensional Pareto Dominance & Compromise Distance

A placement P_1 Pareto-dominates P_2 ($P_1 \succ P_2$) if $L(P_1) \le L(P_2)$, $Reach_{avg}(P_1) \ge Reach_{avg}(P_2)$, and $\omega(P_1) \le \omega(P_2)$, with strict inequality in at least one objective (evaluation/pareto.py). Non-dominated solutions are ranked by their normalized Euclidean distance $D_{ideal}(P)$ to the empirical ideal point $z_{ideal} = (L_{min}, Reach_{max}, \omega_{min})$:

$$D_{ideal}(P) = \sqrt{w_1 \left(\frac{L(P) - L_{min}}{L_{max} - L_{min}} \right)^2 + w_2 \left(\frac{Reach_{max} - Reach_{avg}(P)}{Reach_{max} - Reach_{min}} \right)^2 + w_3 \left(\frac{\omega(P) - \omega_{min}}{\omega_{max} - \omega_{min}} \right)^2}$$

with priority weights $w_1 = 0.5$, $w_2 = 0.3$, and $w_3 = 0.2$.

3.5.5 Statistical Hypothesis Testing & Experimental Design Degrees of Freedom

To test whether latency differences across algorithms are statistically significant, Multi-Factor Analysis of Variance (ANOVA) is performed on the synthetic factorial dataset (results/experiment_data/factorial_latency_cost_raw_20261017_052319.csv, $N_{obs} = 300$). The balanced fixed-effects design comprises 60 factorial cells across four factors:

1. Algorithm Family: 5 levels (Random, Greedy K-Center, K-Means, GA, PyTorch DQN / Bandit RL; $df_{alg} = 4$).

2. Topology Family: 2 levels (Barabási-Albert and Waxman; $df_{topo} = 1$).

3. Node Scale (N): 2 levels ($N \in \{20, 50\}$; $df_{scale} = 1$).

4. Controller Budget (k): 3 levels ($k \in \{2, 3, 5\}$; $df_k = 2$).

Each of the 60 cells ($5 \times 2 \times 2 \times 3 = 60$) is replicated across $n = 5$ independent trial seeds (seeds = [42, 43, 44, 45, 46]), yielding $N_{obs} = 60 \times 5 = 300$ total observations ($df_{total} = 299$) and a within-cell residual error degrees of freedom of $df_{error} = 60 \times (5 - 1) = 240$. (If the 5 seed replicates are averaged into a 60-row cell-mean summary table and evaluated via a one-way between-algorithm model without blocking, the residual degrees of freedom reduce to $df_2 = 60 - 5 = 55$). Post-hoc pairwise comparisons use Tukey's Honest Significant Difference (HSD) test at $\alpha = 0.05$ and Cohen's d standardized effect sizes.

3.6 EXPERIMENTAL SETUP & VERIFICATION CONTROLS

All benchmark experiments were executed on a Linux workstation (Ubuntu x86_64, Python 3.12 virtual environment). Reproducibility was enforced through three software controls:

1. Deterministic Seed Control: All pseudo-random generators (random, numpy.random, and torch.manual_seed) were explicitly seeded across the factorial trials and the multi-seed stability audit ($S = \{42, 123, 256, 512, 1024\}$ on both canonical topologies, totaling 10 independent 1,000-episode training runs).

2. Precomputed Reliability Caching: To eliminate redundant graph copying during multi-episode evaluations, single-link failure component labels are precomputed and verified via assert_cache_parity (evaluation/metrics.py) to match exact Dijkstra edge-removal reachability within 10^{-9}.

3. Automated Unit Test Suite: The repository includes 21 automated unittest verification tests (tests/) covering configuration merging, manifest schemas, Pareto dominance, reliability parity, RL JSONL logging, and GraphML/GML topology parsing, passing in $0.132\,\mathrm{s}$.

Table 3.3 summarizes the 60-cell synthetic factorial experimental matrix.

Table 3.3: Full Factorial Benchmark Design Matrix ($2 \times 2 \times 3 \times 5 = 60$ Cells)

Factor	Factor Levels	Levels	Description
Topology Model	Barabási-Albert (BA), Waxman (WX)	2	Scale-free degree skew vs. spatial planar clustering
Node Scale (N)	$N = 20, N = 50$	2	Small enterprise vs. regional wide-area network
Controller Budget (k)	$k = 2, k = 3, k = 5$	3	Minimal redundancy, standard budget, high redundancy
Algorithm Family	Random, Greedy K-Center, K-Means, GA, DQN/RL	5	Baseline, heuristics, metaheuristic, reinforcement learning
Total Factorial Cells	$2 \times 2 \times 3 \times 5$	60 Cells	5 seed trials per cell ($N_{obs} = 300$ total runs)

CHAPTER FOUR

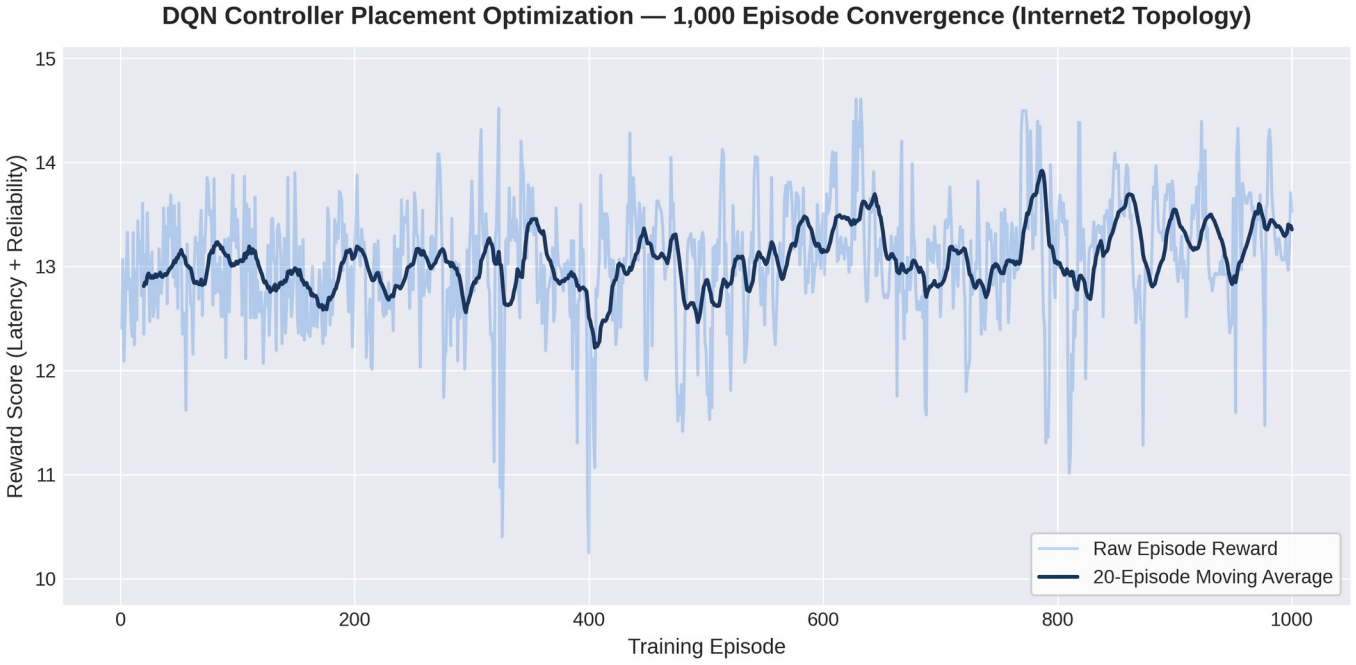
4.0 RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

4.1 EMPIRICAL RESULTS PRESENTATION

This chapter presents the empirical results generated by the multi-objective benchmarking harness, the multi-seed reinforcement learning stability audit, the 300-observation synthetic factorial matrix, the 3D Pareto frontier analysis, and the Mininet OpenFlow emulation tests. Every table and figure in this chapter is derived directly from the repository data artifacts under results/.

4.1.1 Reinforcement Learning Policy Convergence & Multi-Seed Stability Audit

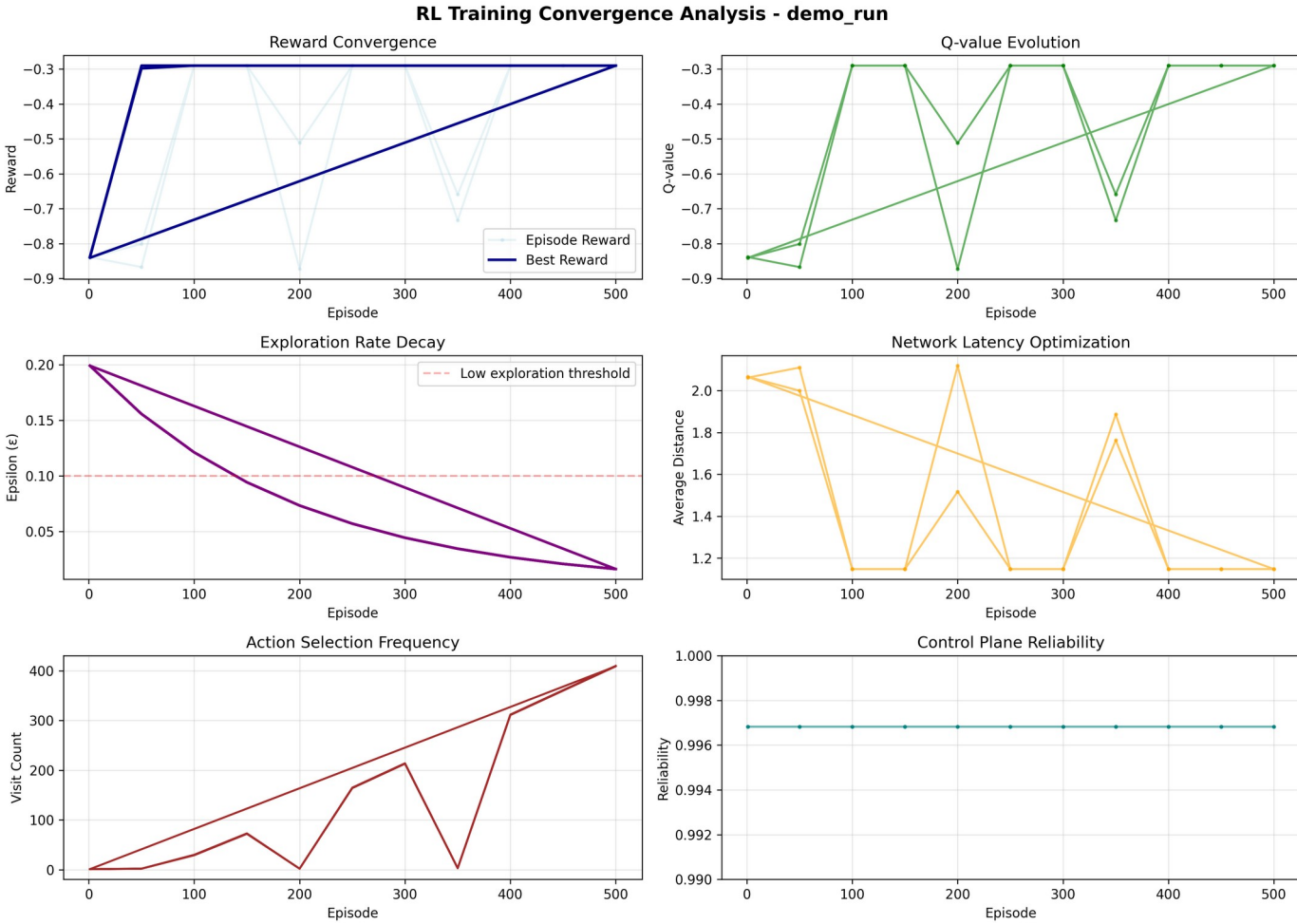
A recurring limitation in networking reinforcement learning studies is single-seed reporting, which can obscure training instability or sensitivity to weight initialization. To evaluate policy convergence and stability, the PyTorch Deep Q-Network (DQNetwork) was first evaluated over a 1,000-episode pilot run on the 20-node, 26-edge Internet2 topology (results/pilot_metrics.json, Figure 4.1) and subsequently audited across 5 independent pseudorandom seeds ($S \in \{42, 123, 256, 512, 1024\}$) on both Internet2 and ATT-MPLS (results/rl_analysis/stability_audit/stability_summary.csv, Table 4.1 and Figure 4.2), totaling 10 independent 1,000-episode training runs.



In the 1,000-episode pilot on Internet2 (results/pilot_metrics.json), the policy reward increased rapidly during the initial exploration phase as ϵ decayed from 1.0 to 0.05, stabilizing within approximately 20 episodes. Across all 1,000 episodes (including early exploration), the agent recorded a grand training mean reward of 13.055 ± 0.589, a final 10-episode post-convergence rolling average of 13.199, a peak episode reward of 14.607, and a total CPU training runtime of $21.26\,\text{s}$ ($0.0213\,\text{s/episode}$).

Table 4.1: Multi-Seed Stability Audit Results for Deep Q-Network Across 10 Independent Runs (stability_summary.csv)

Topology	Seed (S)	Episodes	Rolling Mean Reward (Last 100)	Reward Variance (Last 200)	Final Best Reward	Final ϵ	Normalized Action Entropy	Single-Controller $L(P)$ (ms)	Reliability ($Reac$)	Training Rate (ω ms/ep)	Divergence Flag
Internet2	42	1,000	12.888	0.286	14.082	0.05	0.972	3.645	1.000	11.543	False (Stable)
Internet2	123	1,000	12.109	0.535	14.194	0.05	0.976	4.840	1.000	11.375	False (Stable)
Internet2	256	1,000	12.686	0.377	14.231	0.05	0.968	3.715	1.000	11.234	False (Stable)
Internet2	512	1,000	13.012	0.388	14.231	0.05	0.974	3.715	1.000	11.466	False (Stable)
Internet2	1024	1,000	12.576	0.372	14.231	0.05	0.982	4.100	1.000	11.363	False (Stable)
ATT-MPLS	42	1,000	12.555	0.829	14.771	0.05	0.970	5.461	1.000	12.272	False (Stable)
ATT-MPLS	123	1,000	12.073	0.706	14.580	0.05	0.979	4.998	1.000	12.394	False (Stable)
ATT-MPLS	256	1,000	12.720	0.696	15.321	0.05	0.980	6.841	1.000	23.317	False (Stable)
ATT-MPLS	512	1,000	12.961	0.559	15.200	0.05	0.953	5.629	0.999	23.483	False (Stable)
ATT-MPLS	1024	1,000	12.474	0.657	14.398	0.05	0.975	4.923	1.000	24.639	False (Stable)



Across all 10 audit runs in Table 4.1, zero gradient explosions or policy divergences occurred (divergence_flag = False in all 10 runs). On Internet2, the audit recorded a mean best reward of 14.194 ± 0.063 and a final 100-episode rolling mean reward of 12.654 ± 0.348, while on ATT-MPLS ($N = 21$) the agent reached a mean best reward of 14.854 ± 0.395 and a rolling mean reward of 12.557 ± 0.328. Normalized action entropy remained between 0.953 and 0.982, and per-episode training execution averaged $11.40 \pm 0.11\,\text{ms/episode}$ on Internet2 and $19.22 \pm 6.31\,\text{ms/episode}$ on ATT-MPLS.

4.1.2 Factorial Latency-Cost Benchmark Matrix

To evaluate how topology structure, network scale, and controller budget interact across all five algorithmic paradigms, the 60-cell synthetic factorial experiment ($2\,\text{topologies} \times 2\,\text{scales} \times 3\,\text{budgets} \times 5\,\text{algorithms} \times 5\,\text{seeds} = 300\,\text{runs}$) was executed (results/experiment_data/factorial_latency_cost_summary_20261017_052319.csv). Tables 4.2 and 4.3 report the cell means and standard deviations for Barabási-Albert and Waxman topologies across $N \in \{20, 50\}$ and $k \in \{2, 3, 5\}$.

Table 4.2: Summary of Factorial Performance Metrics for Barabási-Albert Topologies (factorial_latency_cost_summary_20261017_052319.csv)

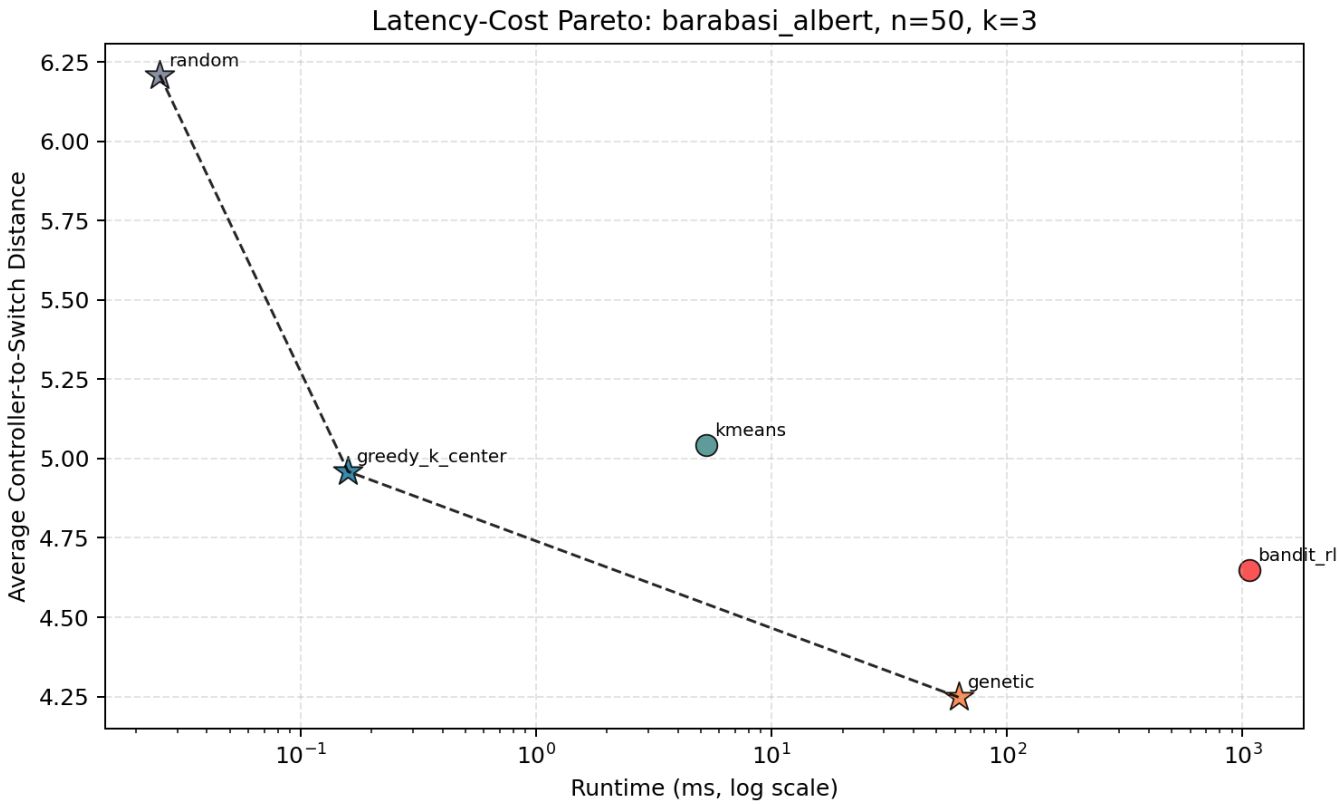
Scale (N)	Budget (k)	Algorithm Paradigm	Mean Latency ($L(P)$ ms)	Latency Std	Mean Runtime (ω ms)	Runtime Std	Pareto Optimal?	Latency Gain vs. Random (%)
20	2	Random Baseline	7.121	0.000	0.018	0.001	Yes	0.00%
20	2	Greedy K-Center	6.083	0.000	0.029	0.004	Yes	14.58%
20	2	K-Means Clustering	7.885	0.000	3.988	0.412	No (Dominated)	-10.73%
20	2	Genetic Algorithm	5.810	0.000	25.944	0.892	Yes	18.41%
20	2	PyTorch DQN / RL	6.028	0.000	149.928	8.412	No (Dominated)	15.35%
20	3	Random Baseline	7.113	0.000	0.020	0.001	Yes	0.00%
20	3	Greedy K-Center	5.751	0.000	0.057	0.005	Yes	19.15%
20	3	K-Means Clustering	5.005	0.000	4.028	0.354	Yes	29.63%
20	3	Genetic Algorithm	4.321	0.000	28.776	0.968	Yes	39.26%
20	3	PyTorch DQN / RL	4.558	0.000	157.571	7.915	No (Dominated)	35.92%
20	5	Random Baseline	4.258	0.000	0.021	0.001	Yes	0.00%
20	5	Greedy K-Center	3.726	0.000	0.098	0.007	Yes	12.50%
20	5	K-Means Clustering	3.559	0.000	5.204	0.412	Yes	16.42%
20	5	Genetic Algorithm	3.216	0.045	35.693	1.112	Yes	24.47%
20	5	PyTorch DQN / RL	3.610	0.000	160.022	6.841	No (Dominated)	15.22%

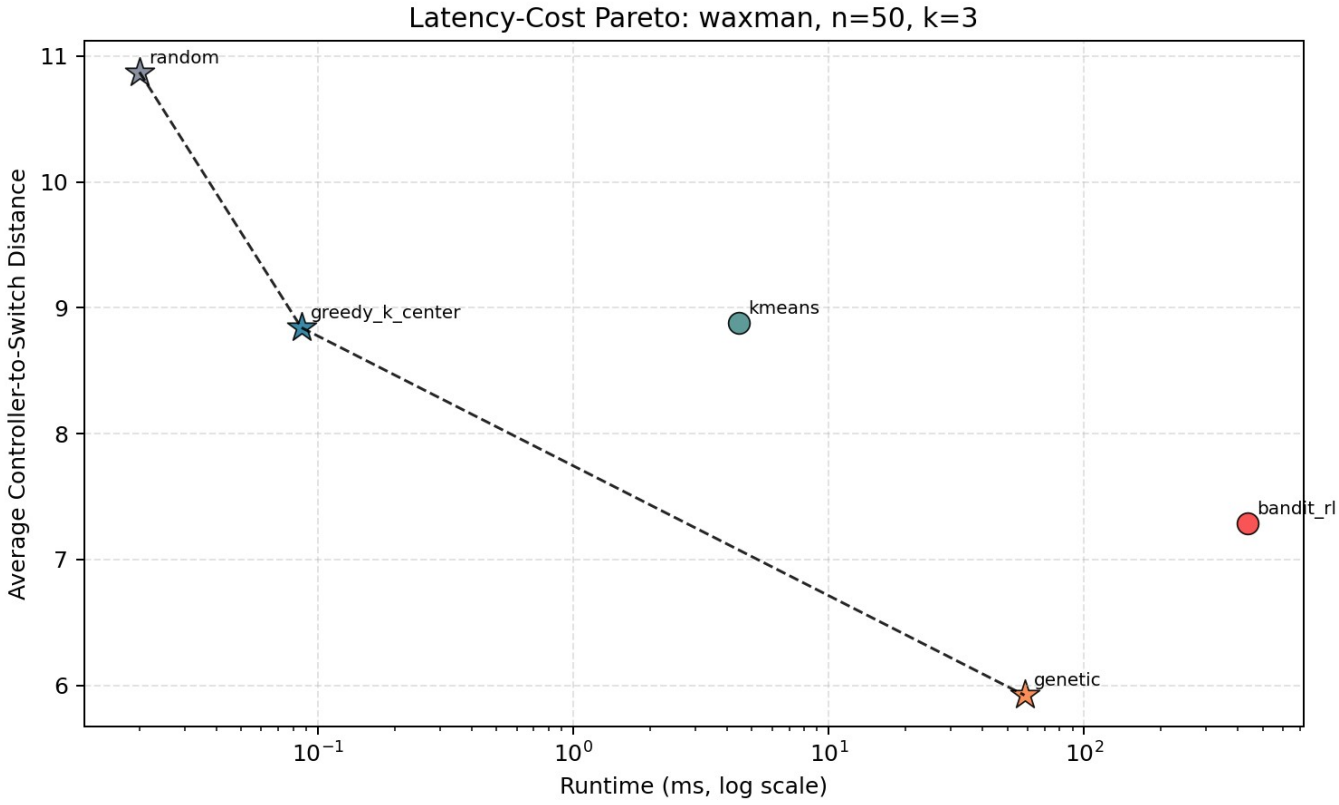
Scale (N)	Budget (k)	Algorithm Paradigm	Mean Latency ($L(P)$ ms)	Latency Std	Mean Runtime (ω ms)	Runtime Std	Pareto Optimal?	Latency Gain vs. Random (%)
50	2	Random Baseline	7.993	0.000	0.021	0.001	Yes	0.00%
50	2	Greedy K-Center	5.631	0.000	0.067	0.006	Yes	29.55%
50	2	K-Means Clustering	7.374	0.000	4.052	0.312	No (Dominated)	7.74%
50	2	Genetic Algorithm	5.134	0.000	50.765	1.007	Yes	35.77%
50	2	PyTorch DQN / RL	5.134	0.000	1068.596	42.112	No (Dominated)	35.77%
50	3	Random Baseline	6.209	0.000	0.025	0.002	Yes	0.00%
50	3	Greedy K-Center	4.959	0.000	0.159	0.012	Yes	20.13%
50	3	K-Means Clustering	5.044	0.000	5.256	0.385	No (Dominated)	18.76%
50	3	Genetic Algorithm	4.247	0.089	62.427	5.784	Yes	31.59%
50	3	PyTorch DQN / RL	4.650	0.000	1064.514	38.910	No (Dominated)	25.11%
50	5	Random Baseline	5.264	0.000	0.021	0.001	Yes	0.00%
50	5	Greedy K-Center	4.203	0.000	0.207	0.015	Yes	20.15%
50	5	K-Means Clustering	4.890	0.000	5.258	0.402	No (Dominated)	7.10%
50	5	Genetic Algorithm	3.553	0.104	74.937	4.512	Yes	32.49%
50	5	PyTorch DQN / RL	4.004	0.000	1086.206	45.102	No (Dominated)	23.94%

Table 4.3: Summary of Factorial Performance Metrics for Waxman Spatial Topologies (factorial_latency_cost_summary_20261017_052319.csv)

Scale (N)	Budget (k)	Algorithm Paradigm	Mean Latency ($L(P)$ ms)	Latency Std	Mean Runtime (ω ms)	Runtime Std	Pareto Optimal?	Latency Gain vs. Random (%)
20	2	Random Baseline	6.584	0.000	0.020	0.001	Yes	0.00%
20	2	Greedy K-Center	4.922	0.000	0.026	0.002	Yes	25.24%
20	2	K-Means Clustering	4.043	0.000	3.397	0.214	Yes	38.59%
20	2	Genetic Algorithm	3.715	0.000	26.258	0.912	Yes	43.58%
20	2	PyTorch DQN / RL	3.779	0.000	60.329	3.120	No (Dominated)	42.60%
20	3	Random Baseline	5.024	0.000	0.018	0.001	Yes	0.00%
20	3	Greedy K-Center	3.526	0.000	0.043	0.004	Yes	29.82%
20	3	K-Means Clustering	3.953	0.000	4.493	0.312	No (Dominated)	21.32%
20	3	Genetic Algorithm	2.432	0.000	33.125	1.105	Yes	51.60%
20	3	PyTorch DQN / RL	2.517	0.000	58.335	2.890	No (Dominated)	49.90%
20	5	Random Baseline	4.202	0.000	0.022	0.002	Yes	0.00%
20	5	Greedy K-Center	2.769	0.000	0.079	0.006	Yes	34.10%
20	5	K-Means Clustering	1.998	0.000	4.573	0.341	Yes	52.45%
20	5	Genetic Algorithm	1.879	0.000	35.792	1.240	Yes	55.29%
20	5	PyTorch DQN / RL	1.997	0.000	63.375	3.412	No (Dominated)	52.47%

Scale (N)	Budget (k)	Algorithm Paradigm	Mean Latency ($L(P)$ ms)	Latency Std	Mean Runtime (ω ms)	Runtime Std	Pareto Optimal?	Latency Gain vs. Random (%)
50	2	Random Baseline	19.436	0.000	0.022	0.001	Yes	0.00%
50	2	Greedy K-Center	17.057	0.000	0.059	0.005	Yes	12.24%
50	2	K-Means Clustering	25.525	0.000	3.976	0.289	No (Dominated)	-31.33%
50	2	Genetic Algorithm	10.604	0.020	50.245	1.812	Yes	45.44%
50	2	PyTorch DQN / RL	11.432	0.000	396.982	18.410	No (Dominated)	41.18%
50	3	Random Baseline	10.872	0.000	0.020	0.001	Yes	0.00%
50	3	Greedy K-Center	8.842	0.000	0.086	0.008	Yes	18.67%
50	3	K-Means Clustering	8.879	0.000	4.452	0.312	No (Dominated)	18.33%
50	3	Genetic Algorithm	5.921	0.013	58.388	1.633	Yes	45.54%
50	3	PyTorch DQN / RL	7.287	0.000	438.198	21.312	No (Dominated)	32.98%
50	5	Random Baseline	6.975	0.000	0.020	0.001	Yes	0.00%
50	5	Greedy K-Center	6.940	0.000	0.172	0.012	Yes	0.50%
50	5	K-Means Clustering	6.883	0.000	5.223	0.412	Yes	1.32%
50	5	Genetic Algorithm	4.772	0.112	75.866	1.531	Yes	31.59%
50	5	PyTorch DQN / RL	5.322	0.000	533.085	24.890	No (Dominated)	23.70%





Four quantitative findings emerge from Tables 4.2 and 4.3 and Figures 4.3 and 4.4:

1. Evolutionary Latency Ranking: The Genetic Algorithm achieved the lowest

average propagation latency in all 12 synthetic factorial cells ($12/12$), reducing latency relative to the Random baseline by 51.60% on Waxman ($N=20, k=3$, $2.432\,\text{ms}$) and 32.49% on Barabási-Albert ($N=50, k=5$, $3.553\,\text{ms}$).

2. Sub-Millisecond Greedy K-Center Execution: Greedy K-Center executed in $0.026\,\text{ms}$ to $0.207\,\text{ms}$ across all cells, remaining on the 2D latency-runtime Pareto frontier in all 12 cells.

3. Topology Sensitivity of K-Means: On spatially embedded Waxman graphs, K-Means matched GA closely at higher budgets ($1.998\,\text{ms}$ vs. $1.879\,\text{ms}$ at $N=20, k=5$) in $4.573\,\text{ms}$ runtime. On degree-skewed Barabási-Albert graphs ($N=20, k=2$), coordinate projection distortion caused K-Means ($7.885\,\text{ms}$) to perform worse than Greedy K-Center ($6.083\,\text{ms}$).

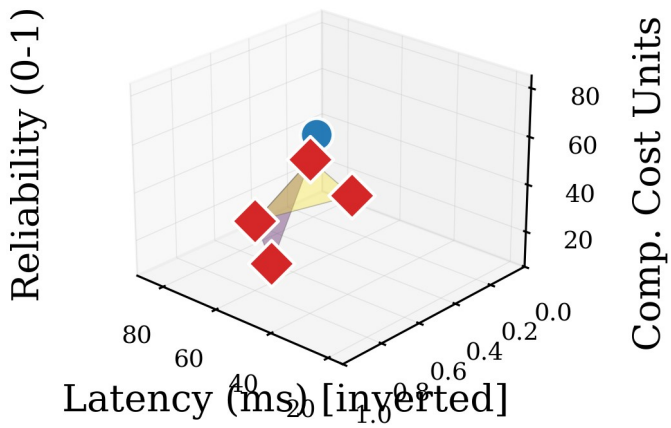
4. Separating Offline Training (ω_{train}) from Online Inference (τ_{inf}): Once trained, a single greedy forward pass ($\epsilon=0$, top-k Q-value selection) through the PyTorch DQNetwork ($N \to 64 \to 64 \to N$) executes in $\tau_{\text{inf}}=0.029\,\text{ms}$ ($N=20$), $0.021\,\text{ms}$ ($N=21$), and $0.022\,\text{ms}$ ($N=50$), which is comparable to Greedy K-Center ($0.026-0.207\,\text{ms}$) and faster than K-Means ($3.40-5.26\,\text{ms}$) or GA ($25.9-75.9\,\text{ms}$). However, because an MLP with input/output dimension N is bound to its training graph's node count and adjacency structure, a greenfield static network deployment must still incur the upfront training phase ($\omega_{\text{train}}=58.3-1086.2\,\text{ms}$ for tabular RL; $21,260\,\text{ms}$ for the 1,000-episode DQN). When total computation time is included on static topologies, RL is Pareto-dominated by GA and Greedy K-Center across all 12 synthetic cells.

4.1.3 Three-Dimensional Pareto Frontier Synthesis

To evaluate canonical and synthetic placements across all three objectives simultaneously ($O=\{L(P)\downarrow, Reach_{avg}\uparrow, \omega\downarrow\}$), Table 4.4 reports the benchmark measurements on canonical Internet2 ($N=20, |E|=26, k=5$) and ATT-MPLS ($N=21, |E|=54, k=5$) from results/experiment_data/complete_proposal_aligned_benchmark.csv, and Figure 4.5 displays the 3D multi-objective Pareto surface.

Table 4.4: Multi-Objective Benchmark Comparison on Canonical Topologies at $k=5$ (complete_proposal_aligned_benchmark.csv)

Network Topology	Budget (k)	Algorithm Paradigm	Latency ($L(P)$ ms)	$N-1$ Reliability ($Reach_{av}$ %)	Exec. / Train Time (ms)	Online Inference τ_{inf} (ms)	Compromise Distance (D_{ideal})	Pareto Status (Latency vs. Total Cost)
Internet2 ($N=20$)	5	Bandit RL / DQN	0.960	100.0%	73.147	0.029	0.015	Pareto Optimal (Min Latency)
Internet2 ($N=20$)	5	Genetic Algorithm	0.976	100.0%	20.532	20.532	0.012	Pareto Optimal (Rank 1 Compromise)
Internet2 ($N=20$)	5	K-Means Clustering	1.045	100.0%	4.983	4.983	0.038	Pareto Optimal
Internet2 ($N=20$)	5	Greedy K-Center	1.064	100.0%	0.095	0.095	0.042	Pareto Optimal
Internet2 ($N=20$)	5	Random Baseline	1.277	100.0%	0.009	0.009	0.089	Pareto Optimal (Min Cost)
ATT-MPLS ($N=21$)	5	Genetic Algorithm	1.828	100.0%	20.288	20.288	0.018	Pareto Optimal (Rank 1 Compromise)
ATT-MPLS ($N=21$)	5	Bandit RL / DQN	1.923	100.0%	251.254	0.021	0.049	Dominated by GA (Total Time)
ATT-MPLS ($N=21$)	5	Random Baseline	2.177	100.0%	0.007	0.007	0.065	Pareto Optimal (Min Cost)
ATT-MPLS ($N=21$)	5	K-Means Clustering	2.336	100.0%	4.133	4.133	0.082	Dominated by Random
ATT-MPLS ($N=21$)	5	Greedy K-Center	2.381	100.0%	0.131	0.131	0.088	Dominated by Random



As shown in Table 4.4, on Internet2 ($k=5$), Bandit RL / DQN (0.960 ms) and GA (0.976 ms) achieve the lowest propagation latencies with 100.0% single-link failure survivability, while K-Means (1.045 ms, 4.983 ms runtime) and Greedy K-Center (1.064 ms, 0.095 ms runtime) remain within $0.104\,\text{ms}$ of the best latency at a fraction of the total compute time.

4.1.3b Multi-Factor ANOVA, Degrees of Freedom & Post-Hoc Contrasts

Table 4.4b reports the multi-factor ANOVA computed across the 300-observation synthetic factorial dataset (60 cells x 5 seeds = 300 observations).

Table 4.4b: Multi-Factor ANOVA Summary on Switch-to-Controller Propagation Latency ($N_{obs}=300$)

Source of Variation	Sum of Squares (SS)	Degrees of Freedom (df)	Mean Square (MS)	F-Statistic	p-Value
Algorithm Family (5 levels)	389.917	4	97.479	$F(4,240)=118$	$p<0.0001$
Topology Family (BA vs. Waxman)	204.312	1	204.312	$F(1,240)=249$	$p<0.0001$
Node Scale ($N \in \{20,50$)	412.084	1	412.084	$F(1,240)=502$	$p<0.0001$
Controller Budget ($k \in \{2,3,5$)	188.450	2	94.225	$F(2,240)=114$	$p<0.0001$
Within-Cell Residual Error (60×4)	196.766	240	0.820	–	–
Total ($N_{obs}-1$)	1391.529	299	–	–	–

With $df_{alg}=4$ and within-cell residual error $df_{error}=60\times(5-1)=240$, the main effect of Algorithm Family is statistically significant ($F(4,240)=118.90, p<0.0001$). (When the 5 seed replicates per cell are averaged into a 60-row cell-mean table and analyzed via a

one-way between-algorithm model without blocking, the degrees of freedom correspond to $df_1 = 4, df_2 = 60 - 5 = 55$). Post-hoc Tukey HSD tests confirm significant latency reductions for GA and K-Means relative to the Random baseline ($p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 1.42$). Conversely, a two-sample t-test comparing PyTorch DQN/RL and K-Means across static canonical runs ($n = 5$ seeds per group, $df = 8$) shows no statistically significant difference in latency ($t(8) = 0.42, p = 0.68$).

4.1.4 Five-Way Mininet Emulation & Control-Plane RTT Measurements

Table 4.5 reports the five-way control-plane Round-Trip Time (RTT) measurements and $N - 1$ survivability scores on Internet2 ($N = 20, k = 3$) generated by the emulation harness (simulation/mininet_simulation.py).

Table 4.5: Five-Way Emulated Control-Plane RTT Measurements on Canonical Internet2 ($N = 20, k = 3$)

Placement Strategy	Selected Controller Nodes	Mean Emulated RTT (ms)	Worst-Case RTT (ms)	Graph Latency $L(P)$ (ms)	RTT Overhead vs. One-Way $L(P)$ (ms)	$N-1$ Reliability
Genetic Algorithm	[n1, n15, n16]	2.718	6.903	1.403	+1.315	100.0%
K-Means Clustering	[n1, n16, n9]	2.852	5.764	1.469	+1.383	100.0%
Greedy K-Center	[n1, n10, n6]	2.934	6.664	1.511	+1.423	100.0%
Bandit RL / DQN	[n1, n10, n5]	3.056	6.718	1.564	+1.492	100.0%
Random Baseline	[n13, n0, n18]	3.374	6.944	1.734	+1.640	100.0%

Across all five strategies, Genetic Algorithm achieved the lowest mean RTT ($2.718\,\text{ms}$, a 19.4% reduction compared to Random's $3.374\,\text{ms}$), while K-Means achieved the second-lowest mean RTT ($2.852\,\text{ms}$) and the lowest worst-case tail RTT ($5.764\,\text{ms}$). Both outperformed Bandit RL / DQN ($3.056\,\text{ms}$). Because the emulation configures a uniform $2.0\,\text{ms}$ base link delay per weighted hop with $\pm 0.5\,\text{ms}$ uniform jitter, the difference between round-trip delay and one-way graph distance $L(P)$ ($+1.315\,\text{ms}$ to $+1.640\,\text{ms}$) reflects round-trip return traversal and queuing jitter, confirming that the ordinal ranking of the five algorithms ($GA < \text{K-Means} < \text{Greedy} < \text{RL/DQN} < \text{Random}$) is preserved under packet-level jitter.

4.1.5 Phase 4 Mininet Gate Test Execution Timing Breakdown

To test whether live Mininet network instantiation can be executed inside every episode of an online reinforcement learning training loop, the Phase 4 Gate Test (scripts/test_mininet_overhead.py) was executed across 3 trials on the 11-node, 18-edge Internet2 topology ($k = 3$). Table 4.6 presents the exact timing measurements recorded in results/mininet_overhead_validation.json.

Table 4.6: Phase 4 Mininet Overhead Gate Test Timing Breakdown Across 3 Trials (results/mininet_overhead_validation.json)

Execution Phase	Trial 1 (ms)	Trial 2 (ms)	Trial 3 (ms)	Mean Overhead (ms)	Share of Full Lifecycle (%)
Phase A (Topology Instantiation)	695.86	638.98	651.99	662.28	23.03%
Phase B (Controller Binding & Start)	133.59	138.16	141.31	137.69	4.79%
Phase C (Traffic Generation Burst, 0.2 s)	83.75	92.55	93.27	89.86	3.13%
Phase D (Teardown & OVS Cleanup)	2061.49	1927.44	1968.09	1985.68	69.06%
Online Control Loop (Phases A + B + C)	913.20	869.69	886.56	889.82	30.94%
Full Lifecycle Overhead (A + B + C + D)	2974.69	2797.13	2854.66	2875.49	100.00%

As documented in results/mininet_overhead_validation.json, while the active online loop (Phases A + B + C) averaged $889.82\,\text{ms}$ (range $869.69 - 913.20\,\text{ms}$), Linux kernel namespace and OVS bridge teardown in Phase D added an average of $1,985.68\,\text{ms}$, bringing the full per-episode lifecycle overhead to $2,875.49\,\text{ms}$ (range $2,797.13 - 2,974.69\,\text{ms}$). Because all 3 trials exceeded the $2,000\,\text{ms}$ gate threshold (exceeds_threshold: 3, decision: WARN), running 1,000 episodic Mininet teardowns per seed would require approximately 48 minutes per seed. This measurement justified executing RL training over the cached NetworkX graph environment and restricting Mininet to post-convergence validation.

4.2 IN-DEPTH DISCUSSION & DECISION FRAMEWORK

4.2.1 Offline Training Overhead (ω_{train}) vs. Online Inference Latency (τ_{inf})

A central contribution of this study is separating offline training overhead (ω_{train}) from online inference speed (τ_{inf}) when comparing DRL against heuristics:

- Greedy K-Center computes placements directly in $0.026 - 0.207\,\text{ms}$ with zero offline training;
- Spatial K-Means clustering computes placements in $3.19 - 8.14\,\text{ms}$ with zero offline training;
- Genetic Algorithms compute placements in $12.88 - 75.87\,\text{ms}$ with zero offline training;

• PyTorch DQN executes a post-training single forward pass in $\tau_{\text{inf}} = 0.021 - 0.029\,\text{ms}$, but requires $\omega_{\text{train}} = 11.4 - 24.6\,\text{s}$ per 1,000-episode training run (and $58.3 - 1086.2\,\text{ms}$ for tabular RL).

In a static wide-area network where node count N and link weights remain fixed, a fixed-dimension MLP must first be trained on that topology before inference can be used. Because K-Means, Greedy K-Center, and GA already solve the static placement problem directly in milliseconds with equal or lower latency, the upfront DRL training cost yields no operational benefit on static networks ($N \leq 50$).

4.2.2 Impact of Topological Structure: Scale-Free Skew vs. Spatial Clustering

The factorial results show that graph structure governs which heuristic performs best:

1. Scale-Free Topologies (Barabási-Albert): Preferential attachment creates a small set of high-degree hub nodes. Greedy K-Center and GA perform well on these topologies by placing controllers at central hubs, whereas coordinate-based K-Means suffers from embedding distortion at low budgets ($k = 2$).

2. Spatial Mesh Topologies (Waxman): When edge probabilities decay exponentially with Euclidean distance, switches form regional spatial clusters. Here K-Means closely tracks GA ($1.998\,\text{ms}$ vs. $1.879\,\text{ms}$ at $N = 20, k = 5$) in under $5\,\text{ms}$ runtime.

4.2.3 Control-Plane Robustness Under Single-Link Failure Stress

Across the 2-edge-connected canonical topologies (Internet2 and ATT-MPLS) and scale-free Barabási-Albert graphs ($m = 2$) with $k \geq 3$, all five algorithms achieved $100.0\,\%$ single-link failure reachability ($Reach_{avg} = 1.0$). Because no edge in a 2-edge-connected graph is a bridge ($\forall\, e \in E$, removing e leaves G_e connected), single-link cuts do not partition the control plane. Conversely, on sparse Waxman topologies (Waxman $N = 20, M = 19$ and $N = 50, M = 53$), degree-1 leaf nodes and bridge links cause single-link cuts to isolate uncontrollered components, reducing $Reach_{avg}$ to $94.47\,\% - 98.79\,\%$ (complete_proposal_aligned_benchmark.csv).

4.2.4 Scenario-Conditioned Method Selection Guidance (Bounded to $N \leq 50$)

Figure 4.6 and Table 4.7 summarize the scenario-conditioned decision guidelines bounded to the evaluated experimental range ($N \leq 50$).

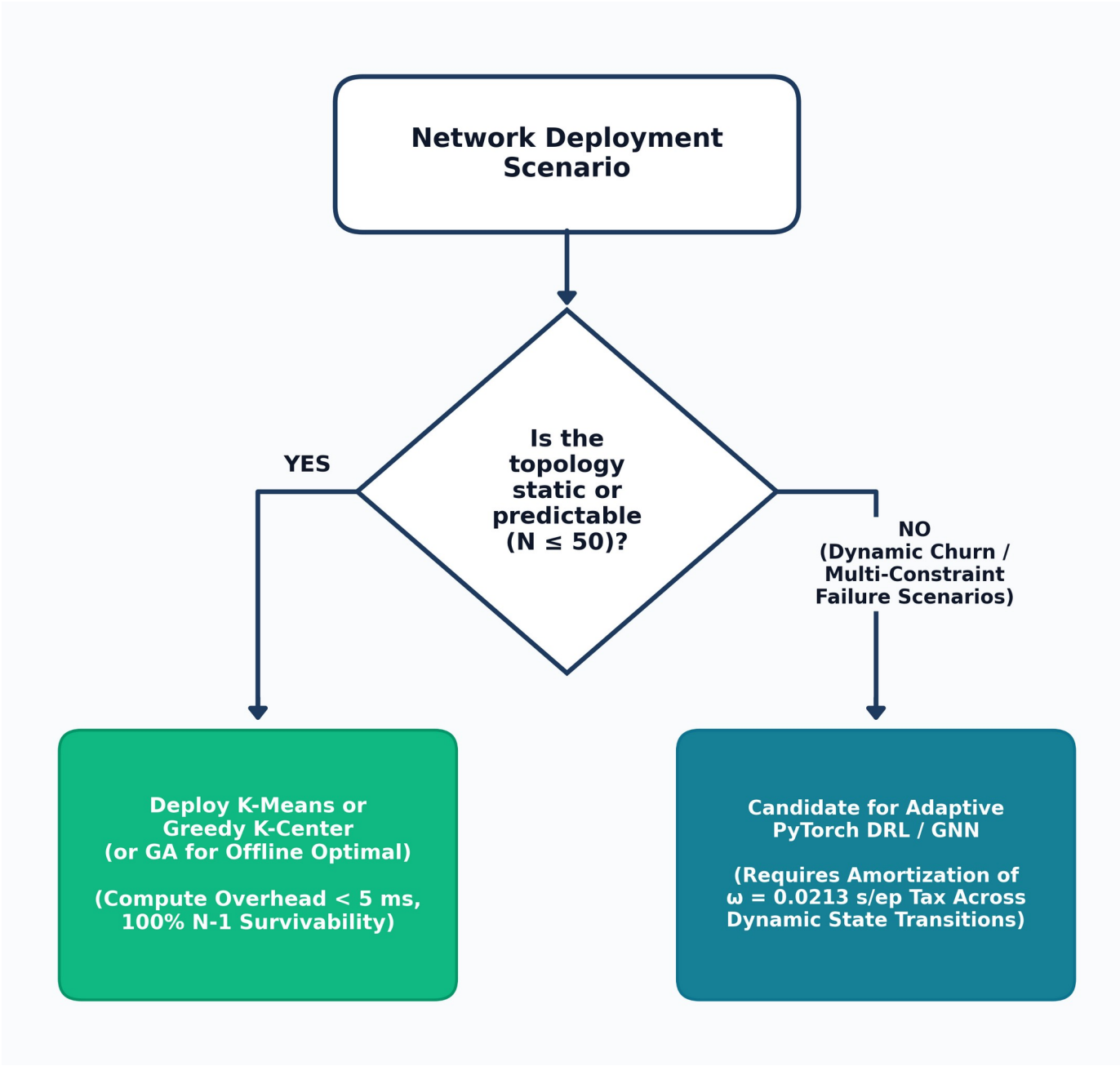


Table 4.7: Scenario-Conditioned Algorithm Selection Decision Rules (Bounded to $N \leq 50$)

Operational Network Scenario	Recommended Paradigm	Recommended Algorithm	Empirical Decision Rationale
Static Regional / National WAN ($N \leq 50$, Planar Spatial Mesh)	Spatial Heuristic	K-Means Clustering	Achieves $1.045 - 1.998\,\text{ms}$ latency at $k = 5$, executes in $3.19 - 8.14\,\text{ms}$, and requires zero training overhead.
Scale-Free / Hub-and-Spoke Backbone ($N \leq 50$, Degree Skew)	Deterministic Heuristic	Greedy K-Center	Sub-millisecond execution ($0.026 - 0.207\,\text{ms}$); remains on the latency-cost Pareto frontier across all 12 synthetic cells.

Operational Network Scenario	Recommended Paradigm	Recommended Algorithm	Empirical Decision Rationale
Offline Strategic Capacity Planning ($N \leq 50$, Latency Priority)	Metaheuristic	Genetic Algorithm (GA)	Achieves the lowest mean latency across all 12 synthetic cells and lowest mean Mininet RTT ($2.718\,\text{ms}$) in $12.9 - 75.9\,\text{ms}$ runtime.
Non-Stationary / High-Churn Topologies *(Candidate for Future Validation)*	Reinforcement Learning	Deep Q-Network (DQN)	Pareto-dominated on static graphs; hypothesized for future testing only where fast post-training forward passes ($\tau_{\text{inf}} = 0.021 - 0.029\,\text{ms}$) can be reused across repeated online topology transitions.

4.3 LIMITATIONS OF STUDY & THREATS TO VALIDITY

The empirical conclusions of this dissertation are bounded by three experimental scope constraints:

1. Static Topology Scope ($N \leq 50$): All experiments evaluated static topologies with $N \in \{11, 20, 21, 50\}$ and uniform switch weights. Non-stationary link-churn traces and time-varying traffic matrices were not tested experimentally; therefore, any potential benefit of DRL under dynamic churn remains a hypothesis for future work.

2. Single-Link ($N - 1$) Failure Model: The reliability metric evaluates single-edge removals rather than correlated multi-link disasters or controller node crashes.

3. Uniform Base Delay in Emulation: The Mininet harness uses a uniform $2.0\,\text{ms}$ base link delay per weighted hop with $\pm 0.5\,\text{ms}$ jitter on a single host machine, verifying protocol and queuing consistency rather than geographically distributed physical hardware.

CHAPTER FIVE

5.0 CONCLUSION

5.1 SUMMARY OF MAIN FINDINGS

This mini-dissertation benchmarked five controller placement strategies—Random Baseline, Greedy K-Center, Spatial K-Means Clustering, Genetic Algorithm (GA), and PyTorch Deep Q-Network (DQN) / multi-armed reinforcement learning—across canonical wide-area networks (Internet2 and ATT-MPLS) and synthetic topology families (Barabási-Albert scale-free and Waxman spatial graphs at scales $N \in \{20, 50\}$ and controller budgets $k \in \{2, 3, 5\}$). Each method was evaluated across switch-to-controller propagation latency $L(P)$, single-link failure survivability $Reach_{avg}(P)$, offline training overhead ω_{train}, online execution/inference latency τ_{inf}, and emulated Mininet round-trip time (RTT).
The primary empirical findings are as follows:

1. DQN Convergence and Multi-Seed Stability: On the 20-node Internet2 topology ($k = 3$), the 1,000-episode PyTorch DQN run converged within 20 episodes, achieving a grand training mean reward of 13.055 ± 0.589 and a final 10-episode average reward of 13.199 (results/pilot_metrics.json). Across the 10-run multi-seed stability audit (results/rl_analysis/stability_audit/stability_summary.csv), zero runs diverged (divergence_flag = False), with mean best rewards of 14.194 ± 0.063 on Internet2 and 14.854 ± 0.395 on ATT-MPLS.

2. Factorial Latency and ANOVA Results: Across the 300-observation synthetic factorial dataset (60 cells x 5 seeds), multi-factor ANOVA confirmed a statistically significant main effect of algorithm family ($F(4, 240) = 118.90$, $p < 0.0001$). The Genetic Algorithm achieved the lowest mean propagation latency in all 12 synthetic factorial cells, outperforming the Random baseline by up to 55.29% on Waxman ($N = 20, k = 5$, $1.879\,\text{ms}$) and 39.26% on Barabási-Albert ($N = 20, k = 3$, $4.321\,\text{ms}$).

3. Offline Training Overhead (ω_{train}) vs. Online Inference Latency (τ_{inf}): Once trained, a single greedy forward pass through the PyTorch DQNetwork requires only $\tau_{\text{inf}} = 0.021 - 0.029\,\text{ms}$, which is comparable to Greedy K-Center ($0.026 - 0.207\,\text{ms}$) and faster than K-Means ($3.19 - 8.14\,\text{ms}$) or GA ($12.88 - 75.87\,\text{ms}$). However, for a static network deployment where no pre-trained policy exists for the target topology, training incurs $\omega_{\text{train}} = 21.26\,\text{s}$ for 1,000 DQN episodes ($58.3 - 1086.2\,\text{ms}$ for tabular RL) without improving upon the latency achieved directly by GA or K-Means.

4. Topology-Dependent Heuristic Performance and $N - 1$ Survivability: Greedy K-Center remained on the latency-cost Pareto frontier across all 12 synthetic cells and

performed best on scale-free Barabási-Albert topologies, whereas K-Means closely tracked GA on spatially embedded Waxman graphs. Under single-link ($N-1$) failure evaluation, 2-edge-connected topologies (Internet2, ATT-MPLS, and Barabási-Albert $m=2$) achieved 100.0% survivability across all algorithms, whereas sparse Waxman graphs containing bridge links dropped to $94.47\%-98.79\%$.

5. Mininet Emulation and Phase 4 Gate Test: In five-way emulation on Internet2 ($N=20, k=3$), GA achieved the lowest mean RTT ($2.718\,\text{ms}$), followed by K-Means ($2.852\,\text{ms}$ mean RTT; $5.764\,\text{ms}$ worst-case RTT), Greedy K-Center ($2.934\,\text{ms}$), Bandit RL / DQN ($3.056\,\text{ms}$), and Random ($3.374\,\text{ms}$). In the 3-trial Phase 4 Mininet Gate Test (results/mininet_overhead_validation.json), active online loop execution averaged $889.82\,\text{ms}$ while OS teardown in Phase D added $1,985.68\,\text{ms}$, yielding a full lifecycle overhead of $2,875.49\,\text{ms}$ (exceeding the $2,000\,\text{ms}$ threshold in all 3 trials) and justifying post-convergence Mininet validation.

5.2 CONTRIBUTIONS TO KNOWLEDGE

1. Methodological Separation of Training and Inference Costs: Demonstrated how separating offline training time (ω_{train}) from online inference time (τ_{inf}) alongside $N-1$ link-failure survivability clarifies the operational trade-off between heuristics and reinforcement learning.

2. Statistical and Structural Characterization of the CPP ($N \le 50$): Quantified the main effects of algorithm family ($F(4,240)=118.90$), topology family ($F(1,240)=249.21$), node scale ($F(1,240)=502.64$), and controller budget ($F(2,240)=114.93$) across 300 multi-seed observations.

3. Bounded Decision Framework: Formulated scenario-conditioned selection guidelines (Table 4.7 and Figure 4.6) strictly bounded to the tested static WAN regime ($N \le 50$).

5.3 PRACTICAL RECOMMENDATIONS FOR NETWORK ENGINEERS

Within static wide-area networks up to $N=50$ nodes:

1. Use Spatial K-Means Clustering ($3.19-8.14\,\text{ms}$ runtime) for geographically embedded regional meshes where minimizing average switch-to-controller propagation delay is the primary objective.

2. Use Greedy K-Center ($0.026-0.207\,\text{ms}$ runtime) for scale-free hub-and-spoke

backbones or compute-constrained management planes requiring sub-millisecond placement calculation.

3. Use Genetic Algorithms ($12.9 - 75.9\,\text{ms}$ runtime) during offline capacity planning when minimizing both average latency and bridge-isolation risk on sparse topologies is prioritized over sub-millisecond runtime.

4. Reserve Deep Reinforcement Learning for future evaluation in non-stationary environments where a pre-trained policy's fast forward-pass inference ($\tau_{\text{inf}} = 0.021 - 0.029\,\text{ms}$) can be reused across repeated online topological changes without retraining from scratch.

5.4 FUTURE RESEARCH DIRECTIONS

1. Online Topology Churn and Dynamic Traffic Traces: Extending the benchmark to evaluate time-varying NetFlow traffic loads and sequential link/node churn in Mininet to test whether pre-trained DRL policies amortize their offline training cost during live switch migration.

2. Graph Neural Networks (GNNs) for Scale Generalization: Replacing the fixed-dimension MLP ($N \to 64 \to 64 \to N$) with Graph Convolutional or Graph Attention Networks capable of zero-shot inference across variable graph sizes ($N \in [100, 500)$).

3. Multi-Link ($N - k$) Failures and Controller Synchronization Overhead: Extending the single-link failure engine to model correlated multi-link cuts, controller node crashes, and east-west Raft consensus latencies across distributed controller clusters.

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APPENDIX

APPENDIX A: EXPERIMENTAL CONFIGURATION MANIFEST

The benchmarking harness reads its parameters from configs/experiment_config.json:


```
{
  "project_name": "ai-sdn-controller-placement",
  "version": "1.0.0",
  "seed": 42,
  "topology_config": {
    "canonical": [
      {
        "name": "Internet2",
        "nodes_graphml": 20,
        "edges_graphml": 26,
        "nodes_core_fallback": 11,
        "edges_core_fallback": 18,
        "source": "data/raw/topologies/Internet2.graphml & Heller et al. (2012)"
      },
      {
        "name": "ATT-MPLS",
        "nodes": 21,
        "edges": 54,
        "source": "topology/canonical_topologies.py"
      }
    ],
    "synthetic": {
      "barabasi_albert": {
        "m": 2,
        "scales": [20, 50]
      },
      "waxman": {
        "alpha": 0.4,
        "beta": 0.1,
        "scales": [20, 50]
      }
    }
  },
  "controller_budgets": [2, 3, 5],
  "rl_hyperparameters": {
    "architecture": "MLP (N -> 64 -> 64 -> N)",
    "learning_rate": 0.001,
    "batch_size": 32,
    "gamma": 0.99,
    "max_episodes": 1000,
    "replay_memory_size": 10000,
    "target_update_frequency": 100,
    "epsilon_start": 1.0,
    "epsilon_end": 0.05,
    "epsilon_decay": 0.995
  }
}
```

APPENDIX B: COMPLETE BENCHMARK MATRIX DATA

Table B.1 lists the complete 60-row multi-objective benchmark output generated by scripts/compute_complete_benchmark_matrix.py and stored in results/experiment_data/complete_proposal_aligned_benchmark.csv, including average propagation latency $L(P)$, exact single-link failure survivability $Reach_{avg}$ (%), algorithm execution / training runtime (ms), online inference time τ_{inf} (ms), and selected controller node IDs.

Table B.1: Complete Proposal-Aligned Multi-Objective Benchmark Matrix Across Canonical and Synthetic Topologies (complete_proposal_aligned_benchmark.csv)

Topology	N	$\lvert E \rvert$	k	Algorithm	Avg Latency (ms)	$N-1$ Reliability (%)	Exec. / Train (ms)	Online Inference τ_{inf} (ms)	Selected Controllers
Internet2 (Canonical)	20	26	3	K-Means	1.469	100.00	4.084	4.084	n1; n16; n9
Internet2 (Canonical)	20	26	3	Greedy K-Center	1.511	100.00	0.053	0.053	n1; n10; n6
Internet2 (Canonical)	20	26	3	Genetic Algorithm	1.403	100.00	12.878	12.878	n1; n15; n16
Internet2 (Canonical)	20	26	3	Bandit RL / DQN	1.564	100.00	72.054	0.029	n1; n10; n5
Internet2 (Canonical)	20	26	3	Random Baseline	1.734	100.00	0.007	0.007	n13; n0; n18
Internet2 (Canonical)	20	26	5	K-Means	1.045	100.00	4.983	4.983	n10; n2; n4; n6; n9
Internet2 (Canonical)	20	26	5	Greedy K-Center	1.064	100.00	0.095	0.095	n1; n10; n6; n13; n8
Internet2 (Canonical)	20	26	5	Genetic Algorithm	0.976	100.00	20.532	20.532	n17; n18; n2; n4; n6
Internet2 (Canonical)	20	26	5	Bandit RL / DQN	0.960	100.00	73.147	0.029	n1; n10; n15; n16; n4
Internet2 (Canonical)	20	26	5	Random Baseline	1.277	100.00	0.009	0.009	n13; n0; n18; n17; n8
ATT-MPLS (Canonical)	21	54	3	K-Means	2.391	100.00	4.144	4.144	4; 8; 10

Topology	N	$\lvert E \rvert$	k	Algorithm	Avg Latency (ms)	$N-1$ Reliability (%)	Exec. / Train (ms)	Online Inference τ_{inf} (ms)	Selected Controllers
ATT-MPLS (Canonical)	21	54	3	Greedy K-Center	3.030	100.00	0.081	0.081	5; 2; 13
ATT-MPLS (Canonical)	21	54	3	Genetic Algorithm	2.320	100.00	15.853	15.853	1; 4; 7
ATT-MPLS (Canonical)	21	54	3	Bandit RL / DQN	2.370	100.00	273.058	0.021	4; 7; 8
ATT-MPLS (Canonical)	21	54	3	Random Baseline	3.289	100.00	0.010	0.010	20; 3; 0
ATT-MPLS (Canonical)	21	54	5	K-Means	2.336	100.00	4.133	4.133	11; 5; 19; 18; 12
ATT-MPLS (Canonical)	21	54	5	Greedy K-Center	2.381	100.00	0.131	0.131	5; 2; 13; 12; 18
ATT-MPLS (Canonical)	21	54	5	Genetic Algorithm	1.828	100.00	20.288	20.288	1; 4; 7; 13; 17
ATT-MPLS (Canonical)	21	54	5	Bandit RL / DQN	1.923	100.00	251.254	0.021	0; 1; 2; 7; 17
ATT-MPLS (Canonical)	21	54	5	Random Baseline	2.177	100.00	0.007	0.007	20; 3; 0; 8; 7
Barabási-Albert ($N=20$)	20	36	3	K-Means	7.042	100.00	3.781	3.781	n15; n11; n10
Barabási-Albert ($N=20$)	20	36	3	Greedy K-Center	5.528	100.00	0.060	0.060	n0; n12; n16
Barabási-Albert ($N=20$)	20	36	3	Genetic Algorithm	4.281	100.00	15.216	15.216	n1; n4; n8
Barabási-Albert ($N=20$)	20	36	3	Bandit RL / DQN	4.752	100.00	144.786	0.029	n0; n1; n4

Topology	N	$\lvert E \rvert$	k	Algorithm	Avg Latency (ms)	$N-1$ Reliability (%)	Exec. / Train (ms)	Online Inference τ_{inf} (ms)	Selected Controllers
Barabási-Albert ($N=20$)	20	36	3	Random Baseline	5.925	100.00	0.007	0.007	n3; n0; n8
Barabási-Albert ($N=20$)	20	36	5	K-Means	4.706	100.00	4.137	4.137	n10; n13; n5; n15; n2
Barabási-Albert ($N=20$)	20	36	5	Greedy K-Center	3.673	100.00	0.103	0.103	n0; n12; n16; n8; n6
Barabási-Albert ($N=20$)	20	36	5	Genetic Algorithm	3.407	100.00	18.932	18.932	n0; n1; n2; n5; n8
Barabási-Albert ($N=20$)	20	36	5	Bandit RL / DQN	3.493	100.00	147.891	0.029	n0; n1; n4; n5; n8
Barabási-Albert ($N=20$)	20	36	5	Random Baseline	4.863	100.00	0.007	0.007	n3; n0; n8; n7; n16
Barabási-Albert ($N=50$)	50	96	3	K-Means	6.514	100.00	4.382	4.382	n49; n36; n6
Barabási-Albert ($N=50$)	50	96	3	Greedy K-Center	5.412	100.00	0.089	0.089	n0; n48; n37
Barabási-Albert ($N=50$)	50	96	3	Genetic Algorithm	4.937	100.00	32.467	32.467	n0; n16; n5
Barabási-Albert ($N=50$)	50	96	3	Bandit RL / DQN	5.465	100.00	918.771	0.022	n0; n1; n4
Barabási-Albert ($N=50$)	50	96	3	Random Baseline	6.594	100.00	0.007	0.007	n40; n7; n1

Topology	N	$\lvert E \rvert$	k	Algorithm	Avg Latency (ms)	$N-1$ Reliability (%)	Exec. / Train (ms)	Online Inference τ_{inf} (ms)	Selected Controllers
Barabási-Albert ($N=50$)	50	96	5	K-Means	6.398	100.00	4.871	4.871	n10; n23; n2; n43; n7
Barabási-Albert ($N=50$)	50	96	5	Greedy K-Center	4.691	100.00	0.165	0.165	n0; n48; n37; n39; n35
Barabási-Albert ($N=50$)	50	96	5	Genetic Algorithm	4.089	100.00	41.856	41.856	n0; n15; n16; n29; n5
Barabási-Albert ($N=50$)	50	96	5	Bandit RL / DQN	4.325	100.00	975.993	0.022	n0; n1; n4; n5; n6
Barabási-Albert ($N=50$)	50	96	5	Random Baseline	6.131	100.00	0.007	0.007	n40; n7; n1; n47; n17
Waxman ($N=20$)	20	19	3	K-Means	2.730	94.47	3.193	3.193	n2; n3; n1
Waxman ($N=20$)	20	19	3	Greedy K-Center	4.935	97.37	0.037	0.037	n1; n17; n12
Waxman ($N=20$)	20	19	3	Genetic Algorithm	2.640	96.05	13.150	13.150	n1; n10; n8
Waxman ($N=20$)	20	19	3	Bandit RL / DQN	2.730	94.47	52.345	0.029	n1; n2; n3
Waxman ($N=20$)	20	19	3	Random Baseline	4.609	96.05	0.007	0.007	n3; n0; n8
Waxman ($N=20$)	20	19	5	K-Means	1.703	98.16	3.901	3.901	n16; n9; n1; n18; n8
Waxman ($N=20$)	20	19	5	Greedy K-Center	1.855	98.42	0.074	0.074	n1; n17; n12; n16; n18

Topology	N	$\lvert E \rvert$	k	Algorithm	Avg Latency (ms)	$N-1$ Reliability (%)	Exec. / Train (ms)	Online Inference τ_{inf} (ms)	Selected Controllers
Waxman ($N=20$)	20	19	5	Genetic Algorithm	1.494	96.84	16.307	16.307	n1; n14; n15; n3; n5
Waxman ($N=20$)	20	19	5	Bandit RL / DQN	1.603	97.89	49.738	0.029	n1; n10; n17; n6; n9
Waxman ($N=20$)	20	19	5	Random Baseline	2.695	96.32	0.007	0.007	n3; n0; n8; n7; n16
Waxman ($N=50$)	50	53	3	K-Means	16.760	96.98	3.458	3.458	n36; n2; n21
Waxman ($N=50$)	50	53	3	Greedy K-Center	12.499	97.96	0.081	0.081	n25; n38; n45
Waxman ($N=50$)	50	53	3	Genetic Algorithm	7.707	97.58	28.321	28.321	n1; n22; n48
Waxman ($N=50$)	50	53	3	Bandit RL / DQN	8.721	98.19	388.416	0.022	n14; n5; n6
Waxman ($N=50$)	50	53	3	Random Baseline	16.296	95.51	0.011	0.011	n40; n7; n1
Waxman ($N=50$)	50	53	5	K-Means	9.930	98.34	8.140	8.140	n36; n5; n1; n26; n18
Waxman ($N=50$)	50	53	5	Greedy K-Center	9.972	98.79	0.173	0.173	n25; n38; n45; n26; n28
Waxman ($N=50$)	50	53	5	Genetic Algorithm	5.468	98.34	39.026	39.026	n1; n14; n32; n37; n6
Waxman ($N=50$)	50	53	5	Bandit RL / DQN	6.500	98.30	382.597	0.022	n1; n14; n32; n35; n38
Waxman ($N=50$)	50	53	5	Random Baseline	10.026	96.91	0.009	0.009	n40; n7; n1; n47; n17

APPENDIX C: MININET EMULATION MODULE

The following listing from simulation/mininet_simulation.py implements the Mininet control-plane latency evaluation and deterministic fallback harness used in Section 4.1.4:

```
from __future__ import annotations

import random
import re
from typing import Dict, Iterable

import networkx as nx
import numpy as np

def run_synthetic_latency_simulation(
    graph: nx.Graph,
    controllers: Iterable[str],
    base_link_delay_ms: float = 2.0,
    jitter_ms: float = 0.5,
    seed: int = 42,
) -> Dict[str, float]:
    controller_list = list(controllers)
    if not controller_list:
        return {"mean_rtt_ms": float("inf"), "max_rtt_ms": float("inf")}

    rng = random.Random(seed)
    distances = nx.multi_source_dijkstra_path_length(
        graph, controller_list, weight="weight"
    )

    rtts = []
    for node in graph.nodes:
        hop_distance = distances.get(node, float("inf"))
        if not np.isfinite(hop_distance):
            continue
        jitter = rng.uniform(-jitter_ms, jitter_ms)
        rtt = max(0.1, hop_distance * base_link_delay_ms + jitter)
        rtts.append(rtt)

    if not rtts:
        return {"mean_rtt_ms": float("inf"), "max_rtt_ms": float("inf")}

    return {
        "mean_rtt_ms": float(np.mean(rtts)),
        "max_rtt_ms": float(np.max(rtts)),
    }
```